

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1996-03-14

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 . . . you express disquiet that attempts being made to introduce a dis-
3 tinction between "b ahá'í laymen" and "b ahá'í scholars" with respect to the
4 study of the faith tend to generate a spirit of disunity among the friends.
5 your concern is fully justified. Such an approach to the study of the cause
6 would betray a fundamental misunderstanding of the pattern of bahá'í so-
7 ciety as set out in the Teachings of the f aith.
8 As you know, bahá'u'lláh says that the pursuit of knowledge has been en-
9 joined upon everyone, and knowledge itself is described by him as "wings
10 to man's life" and "a ladder for his ascent."²¹⁵⁻¹ Those whose high attainments
11 in this respect make it possible for them to contribute in important ways to
12 the advancement of civilization are deserving of society's recognition and
13 gratitude.
14 in the study of the revelation of god, an individual's proficiency in one
15 of the physical or social sciences, in law, philology, or other fields of special-
16 ization will often throw valuable light on issues being examined, and such
17 contributions are greatly to be appreciated. The field of Near east studies,
18 mentioned in your letter, is one that can assist in this way. however, no one
19 specialization among the many branches of scholarly research can confer
20 upon its practitioners an authoritative role in the common effort of explor-
21 ing the implications of so staggering and all-encompassing a body of truth.
22 ²¹⁵⁻¹. eSw , p. 26.^{214.3}

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216 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
217 76collateral with his summons to the pursuit of knowledge, bahá'u'lláh
218 has abolished entirely that feature of all past religions by which a special
219 caste of persons such as the christian priesthood or the islamic 'ulamá came
220 to exercise authority over the religious understanding and practice of their
221 fellow believers. in a letter written in persian on his behalf to the Spiritual
222 Assembly of the bahá'ís of istanbul, the guardian is at some pains to un-
223 derline the importance of this marked departure from past religious history:

but praise be to god that the pen of glory has done away with the

224 unyielding and dictatorial views of the learned and the wise, dismissed
225 the assertions of individuals as an authoritative criterion, even though
226 they were recognized as the most accomplished and learned among men, and
ordained that all matters be referred to authorized centers
227 and specified assemblies.

The bahá'í dispensation is described in the words of its founder as

“a day that shall not be followed by night.”

228 215-2 Through his covenant,
229 bahá'u'lláh has provided an unfailing source of divine guidance that will
230 endure throughout the dispensation. Authority to administer the affairs of

the community and to ensure both the integrity of the word of god and

231 the promotion of the faith's message is conferred upon the Administrative
232 order to which the covenant has given birth. it is solely by the process of
233 free election or by unsought appointment that the members of the institu-
234 tions of this order are assigned to their positions in it. There is no profes-
235 sion in either the teaching of the faith or its administration for which one
236 can train or to which a believer can properly aspire. cautionary words of
237 bahá'u'lláh are particularly relevant:
238 ever since the seeking of preference and distinction came into play,
239 the world has been laid waste. i t has become desolate. . . .

indeed, man is noble, inasmuch as each one is a repository of the

240 sign of god. Nevertheless, to regard oneself as superior in knowledge,

241 learning or virtue, or to exalt oneself or seek preference is a grievous
242 transgression.

243 215-2. Sh, ¶63.215.4

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77The promotion of learning of every kind among the faith's members

217 is an activity fundamental to the achievement of the community's wide-
218 ranging goals. consequently, the encouragement of individual believers
219 to acquire knowledge, the operation of bahá'í schools, universities, and
220 training institutes, the organization of study groups, and the work of task
221 forces dedicated to relating the principles of the revelation to the challenges
222 facing humankind all represent activities with which both the counselors
223 and their auxiliaries, on the one hand, and National and local Spiritual
224 Assemblies, on the other, must concern themselves. in shouldering these
225 demanding responsibilities, bahá'í institutions everywhere find their efforts
226 greatly enhanced by the assistance of believers whose intellectual pursuits, qualities
of character, and devotion to the cause particularly fit them to
227 contribute their services.

228 A special responsibility in the matter rests on the counselors because of
229 the duty assigned to them to assist in releasing the potential of the individ-ual
believer. The members of this institution, appointed for specific terms, have been given the
task of carrying forward into the future the functions of
230 the protection and propagation of the faith conferred in the will and Testa-
231 ment of 'Abdu'l-b ahá on the hands of the cause. Thus, the counselors are
232 called on to "diffuse the divine fragrances, to edify the souls of men, to
233 promote learning, to improve the character of all men and to be, at all times and
under all conditions, sanctified and detached from earthly things."

234 215-3

235 like the hands, the counselors have no interpretive authority, an authority

236 conferred by the covenant only on ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and the guardian of the
237 faith. while some counselors, like some of the hands, will have pursued
238 various academic or professional disciplines in their individual careers, their
239 discharge of their duties is not dependent on proficiencies of this kind. All
240 of them share fully in the vital task of encouraging believers everywhere in
241 the acquisition of knowledge, in all its dimensions. All share, too, in the
re-sponsibility assigned to the institution of which they are members to protect the faith
against its enemies, both external and internal, a concern to which
242 both the m aster and the g uardian attached preeminent importance. . . .
243 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

244 215-3. bA, p. 8.215.6
215 7
216 1996–2000

The Four Year Plan

217 m eS Sa g e S f ro m Th e u n i v e r Sa l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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Riḍván Message 1996

Riḍván 153

To the b ahá’ís of the w orld

218 dearly loved f riends,

our hearts overflowing with gratitude to the blessed beauty, we ac-

219 knowledge the abundant manifestations of his grace during the Three year
220 plan, which has run its course with the advent of this riḍván festival. The
221 animating spirit of the holy year, which lent impetus to the launching of
222 the plan at riḍván 1993, pervaded this period of concentrated endeavor,

rendering our world community more consolidated, more resilient, more

mature, and more confident than before. At the same time, the commu-

223 nity’s prestige attained new heights. while this plan has not ended on a
224 note of dramatic, numerical expansion, even though significant growth of

225 membership occurred in various countries, it has nonetheless resulted in a
 226 qualitatively enriched community—one prepared to exploit the immediate
 227 prospects for the advancement of the faith.
 228 The magnificent progress of the projects on mount carmel is preeminent
 229 among the measurable achievements of this period. indeed, despite numer-
 230 ous difficulties, the stage of accomplishment anticipated in our message an-nouncing
 the Three year plan is entirely evident. All phases of construction
 231 have been initiated. The structural framework of the center for the Study of
 232 the Texts and the extension to the international Archives building has been
 233 raised up and the work on these buildings has advanced towards initiation of the
 exterior and interior finishing work. The erection of the permanent seat of the international
 Teaching center, the third structure currently be-
 234 ing built on the Arc, is progressing rapidly. Seven terraces below the Shrine of the báb
 are now completed, foreshowing the unfolding splendor from
 235 the foot to the ridge of god’s holy mountain. A watchful public is awed at
 236 the tapestry of beauty spreading over the mountainside.
 237 The physical reality of the progress thus far so marvelously realized is
 238 proof of an even more profound achievement, namely, the unity of purpose effected
 throughout our global community in the pursuit of this gigantic, collective enterprise. The
 intensity of the interest and support it has evoked
 239 has expressed itself in an unprecedented outpouring of contributions, re-
 240 flecting a level of sacrifice that bespeaks the quality of faith and generosity 216.1
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 217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 218 81of heart of bahá’u’lláh’s lovers throughout the planet. That contributions
 219 towards the mount carmel projects have met the three-year goal of seventy-
 220 four million dollars marks yet another measurable and exceptional achieve-
 221 ment, inspiring confidence that the necessary financial support for these projects will
 continue until their completion by the end of the century.
 222 The signs of progress during the past three years were evident in a wide
 223 and varied field. The remarkable efforts to expand and consolidate the com-munity,
 the increased ventures in social and economic development, and the unprecedented thrust of
 the external affairs work combine to portray a community endowed with new capacities.

224 in the arena of teaching, there was a general increase of activity as indi-
 225 cated by the formation of twelve new National Spiritual Assemblies during the
 course of the plan and by the surge of pioneering and travel-teaching.
 226 believers in many countries were galvanized by the fresh approach suggested
 227 in the pioneer call released during the plan. The number of pioneers from
 228 and to various countries was high, and there was a veritable flood of travel-ing
 teachers operating both at home and abroad. Systematic approaches
 229 to collective teaching activities and well-focused long-term teaching proj-
 230 ects were fruitful and were more evident than ever before in a number of
 231 countries.
 232 The energy and creativity attendant to the various developments in ex-
 233 pansion and consolidation owed much to the spirit of enterprise shown by the
 international Teaching center. its constant direction and encour-
 234 agement of the continental boards of counselors; its recommendation of
 235 new methods for the deployment of pioneers, as endorsed by the universal
 236 house of justice in the pioneer call released in the early months of the
 237 plan, and its regular assistance to the continental pioneer committees
 238 placed in its charge; its unflagging attention to the educational needs of the
 239 community as expressed in its interactions with counselors concerning the
 240 inclusion in teaching projects of deepening programs for new believers, the
 241 devising of courses and workshops for training in different capacities, the training of
 children's teachers, and the multiplication of children's classes;
 242 its stimulation of efforts to establish training institutes in different parts of
 243 the world—all have produced resounding results. major credit must also go
 244 to the Teaching center for the influence it exerted through the counselors
 245 on the adoption of core literature programs in an increasing number of countries.
 Through such programs a few titles essential to the propagation of the faith and the
 deepening of the believers were selected, printed in large 216.4

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218 82quantities and made available at reduced prices. The outstanding progress

219 in the evolution of this vital institution operating at the world center was

220 palpable in its preparation and conduct of the counselors' conference last
221 december which set the course for the work of these high-ranking officers
222 of the faith during the immediate years ahead.

223 A relevant development was the notable rise in the assumption of respon-
224 sibility by indigenous believers for the teaching and consolidation work in their own
countries. in greatly troubled areas, such as Angola, cambodia,
225 liberia, Sierra leone, the friends claimed important victories, whether in
226 pursuing teaching activities which resulted in numerically significant enroll-
227 ments, or in establishing and reactivating bahá'í Assemblies, or in initiat-
228 ing and sustaining development projects. in places with recently formed
229 National Spiritual Assemblies, such as countries of the former eastern
230 bloc, the friends have shown an admirable capacity for administering the
231 affairs of the cause. A highlight of this period was the upsurge of vigor,
232 courage and creativity in bahá'í island communities throughout the world.

233 The categories of activity were wide-ranging, involving the raising up of local
teachers, the training and dispatch of scores of traveling teachers to
234 neighboring islands, the inauguration of primary schools, the multiple oc-casions for
proclamation of the faith, the sponsorship of events attended by
235 high-ranking officials and influential persons. The fact that in recent years
236 a number of government leaders of island nations have visited the bahá'í
237 world center is indicative of the vitality of the activities of the believers in
238 these small lands scattered throughout the seven seas. Taken together, all the
foregoing examples of the attitudes and efforts of the friends in different
239 settings demonstrate a heightened commitment to the teaching work and a growing
maturity and resilience reflective of the depth of faith motivating bahá'ís from diverse
populations.

consonant with these observations were the outstanding contributions

240 of the youth to expansion and consolidation. Their activities took on added
dimensions during the three-year period. Actuated by youth conferences and other
gatherings attentive to their interests, youth throughout the world
241 invested immense amounts of time, energy and zeal in the teaching work
242 as traveling teachers within and outside their countries and as teams in collective
teaching projects and, in so doing, they stimulated hundreds of
243 new enrollments and the formation of many local Spiritual Assemblies;

244 involvement of youth in music and the arts as a means of proclaiming and
 245 teaching the cause distinguished their exertions in many places; the spread 216.7
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 217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 218 8of dance and drama workshops was particularly effective; participation of
 219 youth in external affairs opened new possibilities for the faith in this field;
 220 commitment to a year of service was more widely demonstrated; at the same time
 there was a notable increase in the number of youth acquiring formal training and achieving
 academic, professional and vocational excellence—altogether an indication that the youth
 are doing more in direct service to
 221 the faith while at the same time contributing to the general development
 222 of society.
 223 Signs of the consolidation of the community were also discernible in the
 224 greater involvement of the friends in social and economic development, particularly
 in the field of education. in one outstanding instance, a gov-
 225 ernment asked the bahá'ís to take responsibility for the management of
 226 seven public schools, and they did so with the backing of the office of

Social and economic development at the world center. worthy of note

227 is that in Africa bahá'í communities in exile because of political unrest in
 228 their home country continued to develop farming and other projects that
 229 went far towards ensuring self-sufficiency. efforts at improving the status
 230 of women gathered momentum in a number of countries where, in addi-tion to bahá'í
 participation in projects sponsored by other organizations, the
 231 bahá'í institutions set up committees and offices to attend to the interests
 232 of women. The bahá'í international community's office for the Advance-
 233 ment of w omen emerged as a symbol of this upswing.
 234 in a number of countries, too, there was significant bahá'í participation
 235 in government-sponsored programs to improve health; in other instances
 236 bahá'í groups initiated such programs and carried them out. The work in
 237 social and economic development was also distinguished by the firm estab-
 238 lishment and consolidation of a number of major projects and organiza-tions. Three
 pilot literacy projects were begun as a first step in a literacy

campaign which the office of Social and economic development intends

239 to extend throughout the world. The bahá'í initiation and involvement in
240 development projects also resulted in proclamation of the faith as they at-
241 tracted the participation of the public and the interest of mass media.
242 A thrust in the external affairs work exceeding all previous records for a
243 similar period boosted the proclamation of the cause. A prodigy of effort
244 in all parts of the world redounded to a much greater visibility of the faith
245 than obtained before and to a consequent rise in the prestige of the bahá'í
246 international community. The broad lines of progress were evident in the
247 ease with which bahá'í communities, large and small, sponsored or partici-216.9

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218 8pated in public events; in the emergence of the bahá'ís as a force in society

recognized by governmental and nongovernmental organizations and many

219 prominent persons; in the ready accessibility of the media. indeed, the wide
220 coverage accorded bahá'í events and interests by the print and electronic
221 communications media was beyond calculation.

222 in the sweep of activities throughout the world, certain specific devel-
223 opments stood out: the frequency with which high public officials would
224 invite bahá'ís to participate in or assist with events or projects; the successful
225 initiatives of bahá'ís in influencing government action; the establishment
226 of bahá'í academic programs and courses in colleges and universities and
227 the adoption of curricular material for public schools; the use of the arts by bahá'í
institutions, groups and individuals in proclamation events.

during 1995, two major united Nations events exemplified the gather-

228 ing momentum of an emerging unity of thought in world undertakings, and these
engaged the active attention and participation of the bahá'í com-

munity. first, the world Summit for Social development in copenhagen

during march involved 250 friends from more than 40 countries who

229 mounted an impressive effort to acquaint the summit participants and the related
Ngo forum with the Teachings. it was on this occasion that the

230 statement The Prosperity of Humankind, produced by the bahá'í interna-
231 tional community's office of public information, was first distributed and
232 discussed. follow-up activities all over the world included the holding of
233 conferences and seminars, as well as the distribution of the statement. Sec-ond, the
fourth world conference on women and the concomitant Ngo
234 forum held in beijing during September drew the attendance of more than
235 500 bahá'ís from around the world, in addition to the official delegation of
236 the bahá'í international community. in that same year, a third event, the
237 observance of the fiftieth Anniversary of the united Nations, prompted the

**bahá'í international community's united Nations office to produce and
distribute a statement, entitled "T urning point for All Nations,"**

238 216-1 contain-
239 ing proposals for the development of that world organization.
240 Also of particular note among the external affairs activities were two oc-
241 casions involving the prominent participation of Amatu'l-b ahá rú'íyyih
242 khánum. last spring she headed the delegation of the four official bahá'í
243 216-1. The text of the statement is available online at [http://www.ibiblio.org/bahai/](http://www.ibiblio.org/bahai/Texts/english/Turning-point-for-All-Nations.html)

Texts/english/Turning-point-for-All-Nations.html.216.12

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218 85representatives to the Summit on the Alliance between religions and

**conservation, patronized by his royal highness prince philip and held
at windsor castle. during october rú'íyyih khánum was the keynote**

219 speaker at the fourth international dialogue on the T ransition to global
220 Society held under the auspices of the united Nations educational, Scien-
221 tific, and cultural organization (uNeSco) and organized by the bahá'í
222 chair for world peace and the department of history at the university of
223 maryland.

Nor can we neglect to mention certain other significant marks of the

224 period under review. An edition of the kitáb-i-Aqdas in the original Arabic
225 was published with, for the first time, notes in persian, supplementing the
226 text as in the english edition. The law of buqúqu'lláh became more deeply
227 rooted in the hearts of the believers throughout the world, and during the fi-
228 nal year of the plan, the T rustee of buqúqu'lláh, hand of the cause of god
229 'Alí-m uẕammad varqá, took up residence in the holy land. This signifi-
230 cant step also means that all three hands of the cause of god—Amatu'l-

bahá rúẕiyyih khánum, mr. 'Alí-Akbar furútan, and dr. varqá—are now

231 residing at the world center, bringing inspiration to pilgrims and visitors,
232 and to the friends serving at the w orld center.
233 it is against such a background of heartening developments that we em-
234 bark at this riṣván upon a four year plan that will carry us to riṣván 2000.
235 we earnestly and lovingly call upon our brothers and sisters of every land
236 to join us in a mobilization of effort that will ensure to generations of the
237 fast-approaching twenty-first century an abundant and lasting legacy.

The four year plan aims at one major accomplishment: a significant

238 advance in the process of entry by troops. As we have stated earlier, such an advance
is to be achieved through marked progress in the activity and development of the individual
believer, of the institutions, and of the local
239 community.

The phrase “advance in the process of entry by troops” accommodates

240 the concept that current circumstances demand and existing opportunities
241 allow for a sustained growth of the bahá'í world community on a large scale;
242 that this upsurge is necessary in the face of world conditions; that the three
constituent participants in the upbuilding of the order of bahá'u'lláh—the
243 individual, the institutions, and the community—can foster such growth
244 first by spiritually and mentally accepting the possibility of it, and then by
245 working towards embracing masses of new believers, setting in motion the means for
effecting their spiritual and administrative training and develop-216.15

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 218 86ment, thereby multiplying the number of knowledgeable, active teachers
 219 and administrators whose involvement in the work of the cause will ensure
 220 a constant influx of new adherents, an uninterrupted evolution of bahá'í
 221 Assemblies, and a steady consolidation of the community.
 222 moreover, to advance the process implies that that process is already in
 223 progress and that local and national communities are at different stages of it.
 224 All communities are now tasked to take steps and sustain efforts to achieve a
 225 level of expansion and consolidation commensurate with their possibilities. The
 individual and the institutions, while operating in distinctive spheres, are summoned to arise
 to meet the requirements of this crucial time in the
 226 life of our community and in the fortunes of all humankind.

The role of the individual is of unique importance in the work of the

227 cause. it is the individual who manifests the vitality of faith upon which

the success of the teaching work and the development of the community

228 depend. bahá'u'lláh's command to each believer to teach his faith confers
 229 an inescapable responsibility which cannot be transferred to, or assumed by, any
 institution of the cause. The individual alone can exercise those
 230 capacities which include the ability to take initiative, to seize opportunities, to form
 friendships, to interact personally with others, to build relation-ships, to win the cooperation
 of others in common service to the faith and
 231 society, and to convert into action the decisions made by consultative bod-
 232 ies. it is the individual's duty to "consider every avenue of approach which
 233 he might utilize in his personal attempts to capture the attention, maintain
 234 the interest, and deepen the faith, of those whom he seeks to bring into the

fold of his f aith."

235 216-2

236 To optimize the use of these capacities, the individual draws upon his
 237 love for bahá'u'lláh, the power of the covenant, the dynamics of prayer,
 238 the inspiration and education derived from regular reading and study of
 239 the holy Texts, and the transformative forces that operate upon his soul as
 240 he strives to behave in accordance with the divine laws and principles. in

241 addition to these, the individual, having been given the duty to teach the
242 cause, is endowed with the capacity to attract particular blessings promised
243 by bahá'u'lláh. "whoso openeth his lips in this day," the blessed beauty
244 asserts, "and maketh mention of the name of his lord, the hosts of divine
245 inspiration shall descend upon him from the heaven of my name, the All-
246 216-2. Adj, ¶76.216.19

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218 87knowing, the All- wise. on him shall also descend the concourse on high,

each bearing aloft a chalice of pure light."216-3

219 Shoghi effendi underscored the absolute necessity of individual initiative
220 and action. he explained that without the support of the individual, "at
221 once wholehearted, continuous and generous," every measure and plan of
222 his National Spiritual Assembly is "foredoomed to failure," the purpose of the
master's divine plan is "impeded"; furthermore, the sustaining strength
223 of bahá'u'lláh himself "will be withheld from every and each individual

who fails in the long run to arise and play his part."

224 216-4 hence, at the very
225 crux of any progress to be made is the individual believer, who possesses
226 the power of execution which only he can release through his own initiative
227 and sustained action. regarding the sense of inadequacy that sometimes
228 hampers individual initiative, a letter written on his behalf conveys the guardian's
advice: "chief among these, you mention the lack of courage
229 and of initiative on the part of the believers, and a feeling of inferiority which
prevents them from addressing the public. it is precisely these weak-
230 nesses that he wishes the friends to overcome, for these do not only paralyze their
efforts but actually serve to quench the flame of faith in their hearts.
231 Not until all the friends come to realize that every one of them is able, in his
232 own measure, to deliver the message, can they ever hope to reach the goal
233 that has been set before them by a loving and wise master. . . . everyone is
234 a potential teacher. he has only to use what god has given him and thus

prove that he is faithful to his trust."

235 216-5

236 As for the institutions, entry by troops will act upon them as much as
237 they will act upon it. The evolution of local and national bahá'í Assemblies
238 at this time calls for a new state of mind on the part of their members as well as on the
part of those who elect them, for the bahá'í community is engaged
239 in an immense historical process that is entering a critical stage. bahá'u'lláh
240 has given to the world institutions to operate in an order designed to cana-
241 lize the forces of a new civilization. progress towards that glorious realization
242 requires a great and continuous expansion of the bahá'í community, so that
243 adequate scope is provided for the maturation of these institutions. This is a matter of
immediate importance to bahá'u'lláh's avowed supporters in all
244 lands.

245 216-3. gwb, no. 129.3.

246 216-4. cf , p. 131.

247 216-5. AlNz, p. 34.216.22

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218 88for such an expansion to be stimulated and accommodated, the Spiritual
219 Assemblies must rise to a new stage in the exercise of their responsibilities
220 as channels of divine guidance, planners of the teaching work, developers
221 of human resources, builders of communities, and loving shepherds of the
multitudes. They can realize these prospects through increasing the abil-ity of their members
to take counsel together in accordance with the prin-
222 ciples of the faith and to consult with the friends under their jurisdiction,
223 through fostering the spirit of service, through spontaneously collaborating
224 with the continental counselors and their auxiliaries, and through cultivat-
225 ing their external relations. particularly must the progress in the evolution
226 of the institutions be manifest in the multiplication of localities in which the
functioning of the Spiritual Assembly enhances the individual believers' capacity to serve the
cause and fosters unified action. in sum, the maturity
227 of the Spiritual Assembly must be measured not only by the regularity of its meetings
and the efficiency of its functioning, but also by the continuity of the growth of bahá'í
membership, the effectiveness of the interaction be-

228 tween the Assembly and the members of its community, the quality of the
 229 spiritual and social life of the community, and the overall sense of vitality
 230 of a community in the process of dynamic, ever-advancing development.
 231 The community, as distinguished from the individual and the institutions,
 232 assumes its own character and identity as it grows in size. This is a necessary
 233 development to which much attention is required both with respect to places
 234 where large-scale enrollment has occurred and in anticipation of more nu-merous
 instances of entry by troops. A community is of course more than the
 235 sum of its membership; it is a comprehensive unit of civilization composed
 236 of individuals, families and institutions that are originators and encouragers of
 systems, agencies and organizations working together with a common pur-pose for the
 welfare of people both within and beyond its own borders; it is a
 237 composition of diverse, interacting participants that are achieving unity in an
 238 unremitting quest for spiritual and social progress. Since bahá'ís everywhere
 239 are at the very beginning of the process of community building, enormous effort
 must be devoted to the tasks at hand.

As we have said in an earlier message, the flourishing of the commu-

240 nity, especially at the local level, demands a significant enhancement in patterns of
 behavior: those patterns by which the collective expression of
 241 the virtues of the individual members and the functioning of the Spiritual
 242 Assembly are manifest in the unity and fellowship of the community and the
 dynamism of its activity and growth. This calls for the integration of 216.24
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 217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 218 89the component elements—adults, youth and children—in spiritual, social,
 219 educational and administrative activities; and their engagement in local
 220 plans of teaching and development. it implies a collective will and sense of
 221 purpose to perpetuate the Spiritual Assembly through annual elections. it
 222 involves the practice of collective worship of god. hence, it is essential to
 223 the spiritual life of the community that the friends hold regular devotional meetings
 in local bahá'í centers, where available, or elsewhere, including the
 224 homes of believers.

225 To effect the possibilities of expansion and consolidation implied by en-
 226 try by troops, a determined, worldwide effort to develop human resources must be
 made. The endeavor of individuals to conduct study classes in their
 227 homes, the sponsorship by the institutions of occasional courses of instruc-tion, and
 the informal activities of the community, though important, are
 228 not adequate for the education and training of a rapidly expanding com-
 229 munity. it is therefore of paramount importance that systematic attention
 230 be given to devising methods for educating large numbers of believers in the
 fundamental verities of the faith and for training and assisting them to
 231 serve the cause as their god-given talents allow. There should be no delay
 232 in establishing permanent institutes designed to provide well-organized, formally
 conducted programs of training on a regular schedule. Access of the institute to physical
 facilities will of course be necessary, but it may not
 233 require a building of its own.
 234 This matter calls for an intensification of the collaboration between the
 235 continental counselors and National Spiritual Assemblies. for the success
 236 of these training institutes will depend in very large measure on the active
 237 involvement of the continental counselors and the Auxiliary board mem-
 238 bers in their operation. particularly will it be necessary for Auxiliary board
 239 members to have a close working relationship with institutes and, of course,
 240 with the local Spiritual Assemblies whose communities will benefit from
 241 institute programs. Since institutes are to be regarded as centers of learning,
 242 and since their character harmonizes with, and provides scope for the exer-cise of, the
 educational responsibilities of the Auxiliary board members, the
 243 intimate involvement in institute operations should now become a part of the
 evolving functions of these officers of the faith. drawing on the talents
 244 and abilities of increasing numbers of believers will also be crucial to the
 245 development and execution of institute programs.

As the term "institute" has assumed various uses in the bahá'í commu-

246 nity, a word of clarification is needed. The next four years will represent an 216.27

216 28

216 29

217 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

218 90extraordinary period in the history of our faith, a turning point of epochal

magnitude. what the friends throughout the world are now being asked

219 to do is to commit themselves, their material resources, their abilities and
220 their time to the development of a network of training institutes on a scale never
before attempted. These centers of bahá'í learning will have as their
221 goal one very practical outcome, namely, the raising up of large numbers
222 of believers who are trained to foster and facilitate the process of entry by
223 troops with efficiency and love.
224 "center your energies in the propagation of the faith of god," bahá'u'lláh
225 thus instructs his servants, adding, " whoso is worthy of so high a calling,
226 let him arise and promote it. whoso is unable, it is his duty to appoint him

who will, in his stead, proclaim this revelation. . . ."

227 216-6 just as one depu-
228 tizes another to teach in one's stead by covering the expenses of a pioneer
229 or traveling teacher, one can deputize a teacher serving an institute, who is,
230 of course, a teacher of teachers. To do so, one may make contributions to the
continental bahá'í fund, as well as to the local, National and interna-
231 tional funds, earmarked for this purpose.
232 in all their efforts to achieve the aim of the four year plan, the friends are
233 also asked to give greater attention to the use of the arts, not only for procla-mation,
but also for the work in expansion and consolidation. The graphic and performing arts and
literature have played, and can play, a major role
234 in extending the influence of the cause. At the level of folk art, this pos-
235 sibility can be pursued in every part of the world, whether it be in villages,
236 towns or cities. Shoghi effendi held high hopes for the arts as a means for
237 attracting attention to the Teachings. A letter written on his behalf to an individual
thus conveys the guardian's view: "The day will come when the
238 cause will spread like wildfire when its spirit and teachings will be presented on the
stage or in art and literature as a whole. Art can better awaken such
239 noble sentiments than cold rationalizing, especially among the mass of the
people."

240 216-7

while the friends and institutions everywhere bend their energies to

241 implementing the requirements of the plan, work on the great projects on
242 mount carmel will continue towards their anticipated completion at the
243 end of the century. by the end of the plan at riḡvân 2000, the buildings
244 216-6. gwb, no. 96.3
245 216-7 . cc 1:26.216.30
216 31
216 32
217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
218 91for the center for the Study of the Texts and the extension of the Archives
219 building will become operational; the international Teaching center build-
220 ing will have advanced to the final finishing stage. The section of the public
221 road which now interrupts the path of the terraces above the Shrine of the báb will
have been lowered and a broad connecting bridge with its own gardens will have been built;
five of the upper terraces will also have been
222 completed. The remaining four upper terraces and the two at the foot of
223 the mountain will be in an advanced stage of development. other particular
224 efforts will be pursued at the world center as well. Attention will be given
225 to such matters as the universal application of additional laws of the kitáb-
226 i-Aqdas, the preparation of a new volume in english of selected writings of
227 bahá'u'lláh, the further development of the functions of the international
228 Teaching center, and the devising of measures for increasing the number of
229 pilgrims and visitors to the w orld center.

The bahá'í world community will expand its endeavors in both social

230 and economic development and external affairs, and thus continue to col-laborate
directly with the forces leading towards the establishment of order
231 in the world. by improving its coordinating capacity, the office of Social
232 and economic development will assist in building, as resources and op-
233 portunity permit, on the progress already made with hundreds of devel-
234 opment projects around the world. in the arena of external affairs, efforts
235 will be aimed at influencing the processes towards world peace, particularly through
the community's involvement in the promotion of human rights, the status of women, global

prosperity, and moral development. in the

236 pursuit of these themes, the bahá'í international community's united Na-
237 tions office will seek ways to reinforce the ties between the bahá'ís and the
238 united Nations. Similarly, the office of public information will assist the
239 bahá'í institutions to utilize these themes towards greater proclamation of
240 the faith. defense of the rights of the bahá'ís in iran and increased efforts
241 to emancipate the faith in that country and other countries where it is
242 proscribed will constitute a vital part of our dealings with governments and
nongovernmental organizations. in all such respects the bahá'í friends and
243 institutions are urged to be alert to the importance of activities in external affairs and
to give renewed attention to them.

244 The formation this riḡván of two National Spiritual Assemblies lends a
245 propitious beginning to the four year plan. we are delighted to announce
246 that our two representatives to the inaugural National conventions are the
247 hand of the cause of god Amatu'l-b ahá rúḡyyih khánum, moldova; 216.33

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217 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
218 92and mr. fred Schechter, counselor member of the international Teaching
219 center, São Tomé and príncipe. regrettably, due to circumstances entirely
220 beyond their control, the National Spiritual Assemblies of burundi and
221 rwanda cannot be reelected this year. The number of these institutions
222 worldwide will consequently remain at 174.

riḡván 2000, the point at which the four year plan is to be conclud-

223 ed, will come many months before the end of the twentieth century. At that juncture
in time, the bahá'í world will look back in appreciation at

224 the extraordinary developments and dazzling achievements that will have
distinguished the annals of the cause of bahá'u'lláh during that eventful

period—a period which 'Abdu'l-b ahá called the "century of light."

225 216-8 Not

226 the least of the accomplishments then to be recognized will be the comple-

tion of the current projects on mount carmel which, together with the

other edifices on that holy mountain, will stand as a monument to the

227 progress which the Administrative order will have attained by that time in
228 the formative Age. The highlight of such appreciations will, god willing,
229 be the holding at the world center of a major event to mark the completion
230 of the buildings on the Arc and the opening of the Terraces of the Shrine of the báb to
the public.

beloved friends, we enter this plan amid the turbulence of a period

231 of accelerating transition. The twin processes prompted by the impact of bahá'u'lláh's
revelation are fast at work, gathering a momentum that will,
232 in the words of Shoghi effendi, "bring to a climax the forces that are trans-
233 forming the face of our planet." one is an integrating process; the other is
234 disruptive. out of the "universal fermentation" created by these processes,
235 peace will emerge in stages, through which the unifying effects of a growing
consciousness of world citizenship will become manifest.

236 216-9

Towards that end, recent world developments have, paradoxically, been

both shocking and reassuring. on one hand, the disarray of human af-

237 fairs produces a daily diet of horrors that benumb the senses; on the other, world
leaders are often taking collective actions that, to a bahá'í observer,

238 signify a tendency towards a common approach by nations to solving world
problems. consider, for instance, the unusual frequency of the global

239 occasions on which these leaders have gathered since the holy year four

240 years ago, such as the one in observance of the fiftieth Anniversary of the

241 216-8. pup , p. 90.

242 216-9. wob, p. 170.216.35

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217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

218 9united Nations, at which the attending heads of state and heads of govern-

219 ment asserted their commitment to world peace. Noteworthy, too, are the

promptitude and spontaneity with which these government leaders have

220 been acting together in responding to a variety of crises in different parts of the
world. Such trends coincide with the increasing cries from enlightened circles for attention to
be given to the feasibility of achieving some form of

221 global governance. might we not see in these swiftly developing occurrences
222 the workings of the hand of providence, indeed the very harbinger of the
223 monumental occasion forecast in our writings?

even though the establishment of the lesser peace is not dependent on

224 any bahá'í plan or action, and although it will not represent the ultimate
225 goal humanity is destined to reach in the golden Age, our community has a
226 responsibility to lend spiritual impetus to the processes towards that peace. The need
at this exact time is to so intensify our efforts in building the
227 bahá'í System that we will attract the confirmations of bahá'u'lláh and thus
228 invoke a spiritual atmosphere that will accrue to the quickening of these processes. Two
main challenges face us: one is to mount a campaign of
229 teaching in which the broad membership of our community is enthusiastically,
230 systematically and personally engaged, and in which the activation of an
extensive training program will ensure the development of a mass of human resources; the
other is to complete the construction projects on

mount carmel towards which every sacrifice must be made to provide a

231 liberal outpouring of material means. These twin foci, if resolutely pursued,
232 will foster conditions towards the release of pent-up forces that will forge a
233 change in the direction of human affairs throughout the planet.
234 however short the path to peace, it will be tortuous; however promising
235 the anticipated event that will set its course, it must mature through a long
236 period of evolution, with its attendant tests, setbacks and conflicts, towards
237 the moment when it will have emerged, under the direct influences of god's
238 faith, as the most great peace. in the meantime, people everywhere will often
239 face despair and bewilderment before arriving at an appreciation of the
240 transition in progress. we who have been enlightened by the new revelation
241 have the sacred word to assure us, a divine plan to guide us, a history of
242 valor to encourage us. let us therefore take heart not only from the word we
243 treasure, but also from the deeds of heroism and sacrifice which even today
244 shine resplendent in the land in which our cause was born.

for some seventeen years our persecuted brethren in iran have demon-

245 strated a constancy of faith and courage that has produced a vast proclama-216.38

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217 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

218 9tion of the faith, forcing it out of obscurity. here then is living evidence

219 in our own time of the potencies of crisis and victory. please god, it may

220 not be too long before our iranian brethren are relieved of the yoke they

221 bear and are ushered into the glories and wonders of a victory that only the

222 blessed beauty can bestow. Their experience is a signal and an example to us

223 all wherever we may live; for eventually, opposition, as the master has told

224 us, will rear its head on all the continents. Though it may be of a different character
from place to place, it will no doubt be intensive. but, thanks to

225 the strengthening grace of bahá'u'lláh and the demonstration of steadfast-

226 ness by these noble friends, we shall know how to meet the shafts of the

227 enemy without fear. indeed, the lord of hosts has promised to deliver to

228 his people an overwhelming and decisive triumph.

229 As humanity is tossed and tormented by the ravages inflicted upon it by

230 a civilization gone out of control, let us keep our heads and hearts focused

231 on the divine tasks set before us. for amid this turmoil opportunities will

232 abound that must be exploited "for the purpose of spreading far and wide the
knowledge of the redemptive power of the faith of bahá'u'lláh and

233 for enlisting fresh recruits in the ever-swelling army of his followers."

234 216-10

235 This plan to which we are now committed is set at one of the most critical

236 times in the life of the planet. it is meant to prepare our community to cope

237 with the accelerating changes that are occurring in the world about us and to place
the community in a position both to withstand the weight of the accompanying tests and
challenges and to make more visible a pattern of

238 functioning to which the world can turn for aid and example in the wake

239 of a tumultuous transition. Thus, this plan acquires a special place in the

240 scheme of bahá'í and world history. Those of us who are alive to the vision

241 of the faith are particularly privileged to be consciously engaged in efforts

242 intended to stimulate and eventually enhance such processes.

243 may you all arise to seize the tasks of this crucial moment. may each in-
244 scribe his or her own mark on a brief span of time so charged with potenti-
245 alities and hope for all humanity. lest you become distracted or preoccupied
246 with the drastic happenings of this age of transition, bear ever in mind the
247 advice of our infallible guide, Shoghi effendi: “Not ours, puny mortals that
248 we are, to attempt, at so critical a stage in the long and checkered history of
249 mankind, to arrive at a precise and satisfactory understanding of the steps
250 216-10. Adj, ¶73.216.41

216 42

217 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

218 95which must successively lead a bleeding humanity, wretchedly oblivious of
219 its god, and careless of bahá’u’lláh, from its calvary to its ultimate resur-
220 rection. . . . ours rather the duty, however confused the scene, however

221 dismal the present outlook, however circumscribed the resources we dispose of, to
labor serenely, confidently, and unremittingly to lend our share of assistance, in whichever
way circumstances may enable us, to the operation

222 of the forces which, as marshaled and directed by bahá’u’lláh, are leading
223 humanity out of the valley of misery and shame to the loftiest summits of

power and glory.”

224 216-11

225 217

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Latin America and the Caribbean

Riḍván 153

To the f ollowers of b ahá’u’lláh in latin America and the caribbean

226 dearly loved f riends,

As you contemplate the challenges awaiting you during these closing

227 years of the century, you may draw confidence from the knowledge that your past
endeavors have been abundantly blessed by divine confirmation. Some sixty years ago,
when the guardian had called for the establishment

228 of at least one center in each of the central and South American republics,

229 he wrote of “the strenuous and organized labors by which future genera-tions of
believers in the latin countries must distinguish themselves.”

230 217-1

231 Addressing the friends in the caribbean some years later in a letter written

232 shortly after the formation of the Spiritual Assembly of the greater Antil-

233 les, he urged them to exert “continuous and systematic effort,” to evince “unyielding
determination” and to display “wholehearted consecration.” your achievements during the
intervening decades have amply demon-

234 strated your capacity to meet his expectations. you have proved by the spirit

235 animating your efforts to be well deserving of such tributes as “staunch,”
“warmhearted,” “eager,” “spiritually minded.”

236 216-11. pup , ¶303.

237 217-1. Adj, ¶90.217 .1

238 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

239 96The central concern of the plans that will guide your endeavors during

240 the coming four years will be to effect a significant advance in the process

241 of entry by troops. This challenge you will not be facing as novices. you

242 have accumulated through successive plans valuable experience which must

243 now be brought to bear on the aim of the four year plan with clarity and

244 single-mindedness. your success will depend on the degree to which you

245 can, on the one hand, intensify activity in the areas that have already wit-nessed
large-scale expansion and, on the other, exploit the fresh opportuni-ties presented to you as a
result of your growing involvement in the affairs of society.

your numerical strength lies in those many regions where, over the

246 decades, intense teaching activities have been undertaken among diverse
populations. Through these exertions, large numbers from most of the in-

247 digenous tribes—singled out by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá to be the recipients of special

248 favors and promises—as well as people of the African, Asian and european

249 races, have enlisted under the banner of the faith. As a result, your com-

250 munity now boasts of a harmonious blend of groups from various ethnic and cultural
backgrounds.

251 plans focusing on these areas of large-scale expansion will necessarily seek

252 to mobilize an appreciable number of believers within each population not

only to labor diligently in their own local communities, but also to serve as long- and short-term pioneers and visiting teachers in other localities. Training programs, with which many of your communities have considerable experience, constitute a most potent instrument for the accomplishment of such a vast mobilization. we call upon you, then, to support the work of the training institutes in your countries, the more experienced among you giving generously of their time as teachers so that courses can be offered widely and consistently. As you acquire new knowledge and skills through these programs, you will be able to put into practice with enthusiasm and zeal what you have learned, and arise to shoulder the manifold responsibilities that accelerated expansion and consolidation demand.

This mobilization will greatly facilitate the development of local communities, a task that in the past has not been an easy one to accomplish. your labors in this field of endeavor must now be systematically and vigorously multiplied, utilizing the valuable methods and approaches that have been devised in many of your countries in recent years. A host of dedicated workers is needed within each population who, supported by Auxiliary board members, regional committees and institutes, focus their energies on the

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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

strengthening of community after community. let those of you who arise, even when you can find but a handful of believers in a locality, gather them together, broaden their vision, and raise their awareness of the greatness of the cause they have embraced. help the local Spiritual Assembly to launch the community on a path of systematic expansion and consolidation, bringing in new recruits or revitalizing those who, having accepted the faith years ago, have seen their enthusiasm wane. remember, moreover, that in this process of community building the education of children—without which the victories of a whole generation may be lost—must be given due emphasis.

while paying close attention to areas of large-scale expansion, you

226 should not lose sight of the fact that your nations have undergone profound change
over the past decades, resulting in increased receptivity to the faith

227 in many sectors of society. you have, in each of your national communities,

228 developed remarkable capacity to interact with society at large. Through your
extensive work in social and economic development, especially in the area of education,
through your discourse on issues such as the preserva-

229 tion of the environment and the organization of social action, through your

230 substantive interactions with leaders of thought, you are developing a keen
understanding of the needs and aspirations of your peoples which enhances your ability to
present the faith to a wide range of interests.

231 Together with your increased involvement in the affairs of society, you

232 will need to make a concerted effort to attract receptive souls from diverse groups,
teaching them and confirming them in the faith. in this respect, the

233 climate of search prevailing among both the leaders and the masses in your countries,
which has emerged following the ideological upheaval of recent years, is of special
significance. Two sectors have been particularly and differently affected and are athirst for
the life-giving waters of bahá'u'lláh's

234 revelation: on the one hand, the teachers in the national school systems

235 and, on the other, university students and their professors. historically,

236 both have exerted widespread influence in your societies, and should you teach them
systematically, you will certainly reap abundant fruits.

in all of this great endeavor—pursuing large-scale expansion and con-

237 solidation, furthering the work of external affairs and carrying out activities of social
and economic development—you must be driven by a passion to

238 teach the faith. let regular study of the writings feed the flame of your

239 enthusiasm. let his words so shape your thoughts that the most pressing

240 obligation of your lives becomes the sharing of his message with others. 217 .6

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218 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

219 98The designation given to the latin American communities by the guardian

220 as the associates of the chief executors of the divine plan has defined for

221 you a vast arena of service. As you take up the tasks of the four year plan,

222 keep in mind the words of the guardian calling on the individual believer

223 to "... shed, heroically and irrevocably, the trivial and superfluous attach-
224 ments which hold him back, empty himself of every thought that may tend
225 to obstruct his path, mix, in obedience to the counsels of the Author of his
226 faith, and in imitation of the one who is its true exemplar, with men and
227 women, in all walks of life, seek to touch their hearts, through the distinc-
228 tion which characterizes his thoughts, his words and his acts, and win them
229 over tactfully, lovingly, prayerfully and persistently, to the faith he himself

has espoused."217-2

230 we shall remember each and all of you in our prayers in the holy Shrines
231 and shall beseech bahá'u'lláh to vouchsafe to you his unfailing protection
232 and guidance, as you boldly go forth to conquer the hearts of men.

233 218

Supplementary Message—Ridván Message 1996—

Indian Subcontinent and Region

Ridván 153

234 To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in the Andaman and Nicobar islands,

bangladesh, india, Nepal and Sri lanka

235 dearly loved friends,

with bright hopes and high expectations, we turn our thoughts towards

236 you, who, serving in a region at the forefront of large-scale expansion, find
237 yourselves poised to make a significant advance in the process of entry by
238 troops, the central aim of the four year plan. your region, which claims a
239 substantial percentage of the world's people, has a bahá'í population that
240 already exceeds by far that of any other area of the globe.

by virtue of its immense natural and human resources, its magnificent

241 history and the rich cultural diversity of its inhabitants, india plays a promi-

242 217-2. cc 2:1336.217 .9

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219 1996–2000 • The four Year Plan

220 99nent role in the shaping of human affairs. Throughout the history of the
 221 faith, it has been the recipient of countless blessings and the arena of un-
 222 paralleled triumphs. mentioned by the báb in the first of his writings, in-
 223 dia is eternally honored to have had one of its native sons numbered among the
 letters of the living, privileged to behold the first rays of the dawn
 224 of a New day. bahá'u'lláh himself selected and dispatched emissaries to
 225 propagate his faith in india, and, under the direction of 'Abdu'l-b ahá and
 226 Shoghi effendi, streams of teachers from both iran and the west continued
 227 to flow to that land to help the believers carry forward the standard of di-
 228 vine guidance.
 229 in response to the bountiful favors conferred upon them over the decades,
 230 the friends in india have made sacrificial efforts for the progress of the cause
 231 of bahá'u'lláh and have achieved splendid victories in his Name. They first
 232 demonstrated their ability to initiate entry by troops as early as the closing years of
 the Ten year crusade when they enlisted thousands of receptive
 233 souls into the ranks of his followers. The sudden influx of new adherents
 234 to the cause from all castes and creeds—clear evidence of the receptivity of
 235 that great nation—transformed a small body of believers into a vibrant and broadly
 based community which gradually learned to shoulder immense and inescapable
 responsibilities. its valiant members, relying on the unfail-
 236 ing grace of bahá'u'lláh, surmounted the obstacles before them, persevered,
 237 and sustained their efforts until india came to occupy a privileged place in
 238 the eyes of the b ahá'ís of the world.
 239 The indian bahá'í community has gone from strength to strength. it has
 240 established the institutions of the faith throughout the length and breadth
 241 of that vast country, including suitable agencies to administer the affairs of the cause
 in each state; has undertaken countless projects and campaigns
 242 of expansion and consolidation; has produced and disseminated literature
 243 in a wide array of languages; has pursued numerous projects of social and
 244 economic development, especially in the field of education; and, aided by the power
 of attraction of its house of worship, has proclaimed the faith

to many millions of people. from every standpoint—its administrative

245 structure, its relations with the government, its experience in large-scale expansion,
and the devotion of the active supporters of its programs and projects—the indian
community stands in an enviable position at the be-

246 ginning of this, the f our y ear p lan.

247 The bahá'í community of bangladesh, flourishing in the midst of a mus-

248 lim society, is a source of joy to the entire bahá'í world. in recent years and 218.3

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219 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

220 500with astonishing rapidity, that community began to achieve extraordinary

221 success in the teaching field, and throughout the Three year plan it has sus-

222 tained consistently large-scale expansion. its institutions have demonstrated

223 their capacity to mobilize the human resources at their disposal, and those who have
responded to the call for action have sacrificially and with the utmost devotion spread the
divine Teachings among the muslim, hindu

224 and tribal populations of that country. The purity of their motives and the sincerity of
their efforts to address the needs of society have won them recognition from government
officials in the highest circles. Their exertions to promote love and unity among the majority
muslim and minority hindu

225 populations are bearing increasing fruit, a striking testimony to the potency of
bahá'u'lláh's r evelation.

in the himalayan kingdom of Nepal, the believers have, through the

226 integrity of their character and the excellence of their conduct, overcome in recent
years restrictions on the expansion of the cause. They are now

227 held in high regard and are successfully engaged in presenting the faith to

228 the people as a unifying force which can contribute to the progress of the

229 nation. As they grow in strength, they can begin to look beyond their own

230 borders and assist in the propagation of the faith in those areas to which

231 they have such easy access.

232 in the indian ocean, the bahá'í community of Sri lanka, a nation with a

233 predominantly buddhist population, is addressing diligently the challenges

234 of growth. in spite of a number of setbacks in the past, the friends have

235 persevered and are using the power of their hard-won unity to respond to

236 the needs of that sorely tried country, whose suffering people thirst for the

237 vivifying waters of bahá'u'lláh's revelation. farther to the east, the bahá'í

community of the Andaman and Nicobar islands has steadily grown over

238 the years and is blessed with sincere and devoted believers, whose efforts

239 won them the distinction of having their own National Spiritual Assembly.

240 dear friends, the receptivity of your peoples and the extraordinary ad-

vances you have already made enable you to approach the challenges of

241 entry by troops with vigor and optimism, and to give systematic attention

242 to the tasks that must be diligently carried out to ensure accelerated growth.

243 your past exploits were largely the result of the incessant labors of a com-

244 paratively few consecrated believers who devoted their time and resources to the

spread of the cause in locality after locality. if you are to sustain

245 rapid expansion and consolidation in the coming years, it is imperative that

246 far greater numbers of dedicated and committed souls arise to promote 218.6

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219 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

220 501these twin processes. T raining courses—widespread, regular and well-

221 organized—constitute the most effective means to mobilize believers on

222 the scale required. depending on the conditions of your countries, such

223 courses will be conducted by teachers associated with national, state or re-

224 gional institutes, some of which may well have several branches. Although the

programs of the institutes may vary according to the characteristics

225 of the populations they serve, their essential functions will be the same.

226 They should seek to develop in the participants a good understanding of

bahá'u'lláh's essential Teachings and to help them acquire those skills and

227 abilities that will enable them to serve the faith effectively. They should also

228 strive to imbue their hearts with a deep love for bahá'u'lláh—a love from

229 which stems a desire to submit oneself to his will, to obey his laws, to

230 heed h is exhortations and to promote h is faith.

231 while all the participants in these courses will naturally be directed to the

232 field of teaching, a sufficient number will also have to acquire the ability to assist with
the development of local communities. in a region of the world

233 where villages constitute a major component of every nation, a concerted
234 effort must be made to establish in them the patterns of bahá'í community
235 life on a firm basis. This can only be achieved through perseverance and
236 constancy in working with the local communities. The friends in each local-ity must
be helped to raise their awareness of the efficacy of the Teachings
237 they have accepted and to broaden their vision of the tasks and opportuni-
238 ties before them. The local Spiritual Assembly must be helped to take up
239 the challenges of community development and of expansion.
240 in this respect, we call upon you to give special attention to the advance-

ment of women. in almost all of your region, women have traditionally

241 played a secondary role in the life of society, a condition which is still re-flected in
many bahá'í communities. effective measures have to be adopted

242 to help women take their rightful place in the teaching and administrative fields. by
teaching entire families, you can ensure that increasing numbers

243 of women enter the faith, thereby improving the balance in the composi-
244 tion of your communities and beginning in each family, from the moment
245 of acceptance, a process through which the fundamental principle of the
246 equality between men and women can be realized.

247 of course, your successes in the teaching field and in the development of

248 local communities will only yield lasting results if you ensure the proper ed-ucation
of children and youth. youth will undoubtedly be the most enthu-

249 siastic supporters of the programs of your institutes. They are eager to make 218.10

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219 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

220 502a significant contribution to the progress of their communities and have

221 shown, time and again, their capacity to respond to the call to service. They

222 can be trained to help shoulder the manifold responsibilities demanded by

223 rapid expansion and consolidation. but it is especially important for large

224 numbers of them to become capable teachers of bahá'í children's classes.

225 As you are well aware, without the education of children it is impossible to
226 maintain victories from one generation to the next.
227 All these tasks will require your concentrated attention. it is important,
228 too, that you maintain the momentum which the activities of social and
229 economic development have gained, especially in india. within their own
230 sphere of competence, the specialized institutes, the schools and other projects are
each engaged in work critical to the development of human resources. we hope that those
who benefit from such programs will gener-
231 ously offer their talents to the institutions of the faith in furthering the
232 interests of the f our y ear p lan.

As you respond to the requirements of the plans soon to be formulated

233 by your institutions, you must ever bear in mind that you will contribute to
234 the central aim of the four year plan only if you teach persistently, prayer-
235 fully, lovingly and wisely. you should endeavor to bring into your ranks
236 individuals from every stratum of society as you vigorously advance in the
237 process of entry by troops. receptive souls should be sought among the af-
238 fluent and the indigent, in the various circles of urban society and in schools and
universities, in centers of industry and commerce and in the vast rural areas of your
countries. you should also remember that your exertions are
239 not to be limited to your own home fronts, but that from among you must continue to
arise an increasing number of souls to serve as pioneers and traveling teachers in the
international field.
240 in the coming years, enormous spiritual forces will be acting upon your
241 peoples. you should be confident that your exertions will have a powerful
242 effect on the course of their destinies. let the words of the guardian written
243 during the first of the systematic plans to be launched in your region guide your
endeavors: “ you should at all times fix your gaze on the promise of
244 bahá’u’lláh, put your whole trust in his creative word, recall the past and
245 manifold evidences of his all-encompassing and resistless power and arise
246 to become worthy and exemplary recipients of his all-sustaining grace and
 blessings.”

247 218-1

248 218-1. miS, p. 203.218.13

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219 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

220 50 may the confirmations of the blessed beauty be ceaselessly showered
221 upon you, and his All-powerful Spirit inspire and sustain you throughout
222 the collective enterprise on which you now embark.

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Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Southeast Asia

Riḍván 153

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in cambodia, hong kong, lao people's

224 democratic republic, macau, malaysia, mongolia, myanmar, Singapore,

Taiwan, Thailand, and vietnam

225 dearly loved friends,

Some four decades ago, in a message to the first regional convention

226 of the bahá'ís of Southeast Asia, the guardian wrote of the “far-reaching
227 influence” that area would exercise on the “future destinies of the world
228 bahá'í community.” he referred to the area’s “heterogeneous character” and
229 “geographical position,” underscored “the spiritual receptivity of many of its
inhabitants,” and drew attention to “the role they are destined to play in
230 the future shaping of the affairs of mankind.” The remarkable progress of
231 the faith in Southeast Asia since that time, in a period of social and politi-
232 cal upheaval, is but a prelude to the fulfillment of the guardian’s promise.
233 This, taken together with the recent accomplishments of the believers in the
neighboring territories as far north as mongolia, gives rise to a brilliant
234 vision of future triumphs in the entirety of that vast region.

you now embark on the next stage of your endeavors, a four year plan

235 whose aim is to effect a significant advance in the process of entry by troops. Among
your peoples, the majority of whom have been influenced by noble and high-minded
teachings of buddhism, are many who possess a profound
236 sense of spirituality, which is reflected in the practices of their daily lives

237 and in the quality of their relationships with one another, with nature, and
238 with their social institutions. They have a keen understanding of the need for
coherence between the material and the spiritual, and are disturbed by
239 the effects of gross materialism on their societies in recent years. your region
240 represents a vast reservoir of potential promoters of the cause waiting to be 218.16
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220 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
221 50tapped. The number and quality of the active supporters of the faith with
222 which it is already blessed bespeak the richness of that reservoir.

Systematic training programs constitute the most potent instrument at

223 your disposal for realizing the potential of that highly promising region to
224 contribute significantly to the human resources of the faith. To this end,
225 the establishment and strengthening of institutes will undoubtedly be a
226 central component of the plans of all your countries. your participation in
227 institute programs, through which you will deepen your knowledge of the
228 faith, cultivate your inner spiritual lives and develop abilities of service, will
229 enable you to intensify your individual and collective exertions in the teach-
230 ing field and will result in a commensurate acceleration in the expansion
231 of your communities. varying patterns of growth, of course, will evolve
232 according to the particular conditions in each country.
233 in malaysia, large numbers of believers from among the chinese, indian
234 and indigenous populations can be mobilized, and their energies directed towards
the stimulation of activity at the local level. many of the local
235 communities are in a position to implement plans and projects under the
236 direction of their local Spiritual Assemblies, and they should be encour-
237 aged and aided in their efforts to do so. The capacity to achieve rapid and
238 simultaneous expansion and consolidation exists in malaysia, but needs to
239 be fully exercised. Such an undertaking must be complemented by concrete
240 measures to broaden the range of activities in areas such as the advancement
241 of women, the spread of literacy, and the promotion of moral education—areas in
which the malaysian community already has an impressive record.

242 in addition to contributing to the progress of society, such activities will go
243 far in winning the admiration and respect of the enlightened in government circles
and, beyond that, in drawing the attention of leaders of thought throughout the region to the
Teachings of the Faith.

The bahá'í community of myanmar, which traces its roots back to the

244 time of bahá'u'lláh, has in recent years been able to pay increasing attention
245 to the expansion of the faith. The results have been encouraging indeed.
246 The large body of believers in myanmar, faithful to the covenant and with
247 hearts filled with love for bahá'u'lláh, who stand ready to serve his faith,
248 can be helped by the institute program now being established there to enter the field
of teaching with confidence. The effects such an endeavor will
249 have, in a land so receptive to the divine message, are incalculable.

The friends in Thailand may draw courage from the success of their

250 efforts to help reestablish the bahá'í community of cambodia and resolve 219.3

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220 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

221 505to turn with the same vigor and determination to the tasks of expansion
222 and consolidation in their homeland. There they have proved themselves
223 capable of teaching among many strata of society and of bringing into their
224 ranks people of diverse cultural and educational backgrounds. Setting aside all
hesitation, and with unity of thought and purpose, let them dedicate the coming four years
to the unflagging pursuit of a clearly defined course of
225 action traced for them by their institutions.

in vietnam, laos and cambodia, where possibilities for growth exist

226 in varying degrees, the sorely tried, steadfast and devoted friends need to
227 demonstrate to the authorities and leaders of their countries that bahá'ís,
228 obedient and loyal to their governments, desire but the prosperity of their nations
and the upliftment of their peoples. Through the spiritual enrichment of families in vietnam,
through the program of deepening in small
229 groups now initiated in laos, and through systematic plans for expansion
230 and consolidation and for social and economic development in cambodia,

231 where the friends enjoy greater freedom, each of these communities can achieve
substantial progress within the parameters defined for them by pre-

232 vailing social and political conditions.

The manner in which the bahá'í community of mongolia, so young and

233 so full of vitality, has taken its affairs in hand is exhilarating. in the span of

234 seven years, the friends have ranged methodically across that vast land and have
established the faith on solid and enduring foundations. At the national

235 level, they are becoming known for their high ideals, particularly as champi-

236 ons of the rights of children. At the same time, their bahá'í classes, open to

237 children from bahá'í and non-bahá'í families alike, are being received with

238 great enthusiasm, presenting them with extensive teaching opportunities. There is a
spirit in the mongolian people which must needs manifest itself

239 in the efflorescence of a numerically strong, vibrant community.

240 The bahá'í community of Singapore is energetic and dedicated. its past

241 experience demonstrates that focused attention on expansion invariably brings good
results. what is required at this stage of the community's devel-

242 opment is an accelerating increase in the number of individual enrollments.

Such an influx of new souls will continually strengthen the community

243 which, although comparatively small, has demonstrated its ability to play an
important role in the affairs of the faith in the region.

244 dear friends, any attempt to present, no matter how briefly, an overview

245 of the potentialities of your region must necessarily take into account the
preponderating influence that the chinese people are to exert on the des-219.7

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220 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

221 506tiny of humankind. To them, 'Abdu'l-bahá has referred as "truth-seeking"

and "prompted with ideal motives." from among them, he declared, can

222 be raised "such divine personages that each one of them may become the

223 bright candle of the world of humanity." The progress of the faith in hong

224 kong, macau and Taiwan, and the labors of the chinese believers resident

225 in other parts of the region, are early indications of that which is yet to

226 come. we turn our expectant eyes towards the chinese people, confident in
227 their ability to become illumined with the light of bahá'u'lláh's revelation
228 and to apply his Teachings, with characteristic diligence, to the advance-
229 ment of spiritual and material civilization. As larger and larger numbers become
imbued with heavenly qualities, and as they make sincere exertions
230 for the progress of their people, they shall, god willing, win the trust of
231 fair-minded leaders and be able to broaden the scope of their endeavors in a

land that 'Abdu'l-b ahá has designated "the country of the future."

232 we shall pray ardently at the Sacred Threshold that the blessings of bahá'u'lláh
233 may sustain you and guide you in your noble services to his cause.
234 220

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

North America

Riḍván 153

235 To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in North America: Alaska, canada,
greenland and the u nited States
236 dearly loved f riends,

As members of the North American bahá'í community, you enter the

237 four year plan with a brilliant record of progress in fulfilling the man-
238 date issued by 'Abdu'l-b ahá in the Tablets of the divine plan. in the eight
239 decades since you received this mandate, your prodigious exertions have
240 carried the message of bahá'u'lláh to all parts of your continent, and
241 throughout the length and breadth of the planet. you have played a critical
242 role in the establishment of the framework of the Administrative order and
243 in the sustained proclamation of the faith. These Tablets launched you on
244 a worldwide enterprise which you, and the generations to succeed you, are called
upon to continue during the vast period of time stretching through-
245 out the formative Age and into the golden Age of the bahá'í dispensation.219.11

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221 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

222 507in your pursuit of the provisions of the four year plan on national, re-

223 gional and local levels, in conformity with the detailed plans to be formulat-
 224 ed in the weeks ahead, you should constantly bear in mind the one central
 225 aim of the plan: advancing the process of entry by troops. There can be no
 226 doubt that this process, propelled by mysterious spiritual forces beyond the ken of
 the skeptic, will in due course quicken the souls of a multitude from
 227 every background in North America and dramatically increase the numeri-
 228 cal strength of your communities.

229 Training institutes and other centers of learning are an indispensable ele-
 230 ment of a sustained endeavor to advance this process, and to ensure that the
 231 essential deepening of new believers is not neglected, that they develop the
 232 necessary skills to effectively teach the faith, and that an opportunity is pro-
 233 vided for all bahá'ís, new and veteran, to embark on a systematic study of
 234 the fundamental verities of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh. we look to your
 235 communities to make an energetic response to the call for such institutes, and to
 develop a wide variety of approaches fitted to the needs of the diverse components of your
 population.

236 in one of the Tablets of the divine plan, 'Abdu'l-b ahá, exhorting the
 237 North American believers to strive to attain the exalted station of Apostles of
 bahá'u'lláh, specifies firmness in the covenant to be a prerequisite for
 238 this achievement.

239 220-1 we urge you to manifest unwavering adherence to the
 240 provisions of the covenant, while ever striving for a deeper understanding
 241 of its challenging features and of its implications, which far transcend the familiar
 arrangements of present society.

242 you are in a most enviable position to provide a mighty impetus to the
 243 teaching work. Through the alertness and perseverance of your institutions
 244 and the effect of your exertions, there is now a general awareness of, and
 245 respect for, the cause in your region, and the faith has acquired a reputa-
 246 tion for universality and liberality of thought. well may you rejoice at this
 247 remarkable achievement, and well may you contemplate the present needs
 248 of the cause with eagerness and confidence.

your accomplishments have prepared the way for even more spectacular

249 successes in the years immediately ahead. Now as never before should you strive
mightily to free yourselves from the obstacles of apathy, attachment

250 to worldly pursuits, and lethargy, which stand in the way of so glorious a realization.
As the people around you yearn increasingly for a society in which

251 220-1. See Tdp , no. 8.220.2

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221 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

222 508rectitude of conduct prevails, which is animated by a nobility of moral be -

223 havior, and in which the diverse races are firmly united, your challenge is to

224 demonstrate the efficacy of the message of bahá'u'lláh in ministering to their

225 needs and in recreating the very foundation of individual and social life. The

226 whole of North America stands in desperate need of the inspiring vision, the
dynamic sense of purpose and the idealism, which can be provided only by

227 those who are imbued with the spirit and truths of the bahá'í writings.

The community of the greatest Name must increasingly become re-

228 nowned for its social cohesion, and for the spirit of trust and confidence

229 which distinguishes the relationship between believers and their institu-

230 tions. in the earliest years of his ministry, the guardian stated, “. . . i hope

231 to see the friends at all times, in every land, and of every shade of thought

232 and character, voluntarily and joyously rallying round their local and in

233 particular their national centers of activity, upholding and promoting their

234 interests with complete unanimity and contentment, with perfect under-standing,
genuine enthusiasm, and sustained vigor. This indeed is the one joy and yearning of my life,
for it is the fountainhead from which all future

235 blessings will flow, the broad foundation upon which the security of the

divine edifice must ultimately rest.”

236 220-2 realization of this longing requires

237 that you commit yourselves to the wholehearted support of your institu-

238 tions. in turn, those of you called upon to serve as members of such bodies

239 should ever be mindful of the attitude and manner prescribed for the con-
240 duct of their duties, and should strive continually to approach the exalted standard
set out in the Teachings.

241 in the divine plan bequeathed to you by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá is disclosed the
242 glorious destiny of those who are the descendants of the early inhabitants of your
continent. we call upon the indigenous believers who are firmly rooted

in the bahá’í Teachings to aid, through both deed and word, those who

243 have not yet attained that level of understanding. progress along the path to
244 their destiny requires that they refuse to be drawn into the divisiveness and militancy
around them, and that they strive to make their own distinctive

245 contribution to the pursuit of the goals of the four year plan, both beyond
246 the confines of North America and at home. They should be ever mindful
247 of the vital contribution they can make to the work of the faith throughout
248 the American continent, in the circumpolar areas and in the Asian region of
249 the r ussian f ederation.

250 220-2. bA, p. 66.220.7

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221 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

222 509we direct the attention of the believers of African descent, so beloved
223 by the master, to the pressing need for pioneers, who will contribute to
224 the further development of the cause in distant areas, including the conti-
225 nent of Africa for which they were assigned a special responsibility by the
226 guardian when the first systematic campaign was launched for its spiritual
227 illumination. Although their contributions to all aspects of bahá’í service on
228 the home front and elsewhere will be of great value, they can be a unique source of
encouragement and inspiration to their African brothers and sis-ters who are now poised on
the threshold of great advances for the faith of

229 bahá’u’lláh.

230 increasingly over the years, the bahá’í community in North America has

231 been augmented by the addition of a substantial number of believers who have come
from the cradle of the faith. we urge all the friends of persian

232 background, who constitute a most valuable source of ability and experi-ence, to
dedicate themselves, to an extent surpassing their past services, to the accomplishment of the

goals of the four year plan, under the leadership

233 and guidance of the institutions of the faith in North America. The unity
234 of thought and endeavor between the friends from east and west will offer a
235 shining example of the power of bahá'u'lláh to demolish traditional barriers
236 and will be a powerful source of attraction to the cause.

237 The Alaskan bahá'ís are privileged to live in an area described by the
238 guardian as “a region destined to play an important role in shaping the
239 spiritual destinies of the great republic of the west of which it forms a part,
240 and to contribute, in no small measure, to the establishment of the institu-

tions of his world order throughout the American continent.”

241 220-3 The
242 invaluable contribution they have made to the establishment of the faith in
243 Siberia in recent years, together with their significant advances in strength-
244 ening the home front, provide compelling evidence of their capacity to take full
advantage of the opportunities before them in the f our y ear p lan.

The valiant canadian bahá'í community was praised by the guardian for

245 “the staunchness of the faith of its members, their unyielding resolve, their ceaseless
efforts, their willingness to sacrifice, their exemplary loyalty, their steadfast courage,”

246 220-4 a description fully confirmed by the record of its
247 achievements during the Three year plan. it has played a disproportionately
248 220-3. he, p. 36.

249 220-4. mc, p. 60.220.9

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221 m e S Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

222 510great and much-appreciated role in the defense of the faith, in its propaga-
223 tion to all corners of the earth, and in the establishment of its institutions in
224 other lands, both near and far, and is in an enviable position to build upon
225 these successes in the new p lan on which it now embarks.

our thoughts turn often to the bahá'í community of greenland, whose

226 staunchness of faith and dogged perseverance have won our admiration and
227 praise, and have resulted in the faith's becoming firmly established in that
228 distant land. inspired by the promise set out in the Tablets of the divine
229 plan that "if the hearts be touched with the heat of the love of god, that
230 territory will become a divine rose-garden and a heavenly paradise, and the souls,
even as fruitful trees, will acquire the utmost freshness and beau-
ty,"

231 220-5 let them now go forth to claim new victories on the home front and
232 to transform their nation through the power of the d ivine Teachings.

Some four decades ago, Shoghi effendi described the members of the

233 united States bahá'í community as "the outstanding protagonists of the
234 cause of god; the stout-hearted defenders of its integrity, its claims and
235 its rights; the champion-builders of its Administrative order; the standard-
236 bearers of its crusading hosts; the torchbearers of its embryonic civilization; the chief
succorers of the downtrodden, the needy and the fettered among its followers. . . ."

237 220-6 Any survey of the distinguished accomplishments
238 of these dearly loved friends during the past three years provides striking
239 evidence of the continuing applicability of this description, and of the
240 immense contribution they are making to the advancement of the cause.
241 we look to the members of the bahá'í community in the united States to
242 perform, during the four year plan, heroic deeds of service to the cause,
243 which will astonish and inspire their fellow-believers throughout the world.

in North America, there are opportunities for the advancement of the

244 process of entry by troops, the like of which presently exist in no other place on earth.
Three unique characteristics combine to give rise to this condition:

245 the unparalleled strength of your local communities, particularly evident
246 in the activity of your local Spiritual Assemblies and in the consecration
247 of the bahá'í youth; the positive impression of the faith which has been
248 conveyed, not only to the generality of the population, but also to leaders of thought
and people of influence; and the composition of your nations,

249 220-5. Tdp , no. 5.2.

250 220-6. cf , pp. 141–42.220.13

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221 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

222 511which have welcomed to their shores immigrants, students and refugees
223 from all parts of the planet, drawn from all the major racial, ethnic and
224 religious backgrounds of humanity. you, who live in a continent described
225 by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá as “the land wherein the splendors of his light shall be
226 revealed, where the mysteries of his faith shall be unveiled, the home of the
227 righteous, and the gathering-place of the free,”220-7 are called upon to take
228 full advantage of these favorable circumstances.

dear friends, now must you commit yourselves to the work of the cause

229 afresh, liberated from any doubts, uncertainties or hesitations which may
230 have impeded you in the past. every stratum of society must be brought
231 within your embrace, as you vigorously advance toward the goal of entry by troops
at this time when powerful spiritual forces are at work in the hearts of the people. Neither
the affluent nor the indigent should be excluded from your purview. receptive souls should
be sought in the sophisticated circles
232 of urban society, on the campuses of colleges and universities, in centers of industry
and commerce, on the farms and villages of the mountains, plains and prairies—wherever
are to be found human beings in search of
233 the divine T ruth. you should strive to create a bahá’í community which will
234 offer to the entire world a vibrant model of unity in diversity. The influence
235 of your exertions can extend well beyond the confines of North America; in
particular, french canadian believers can perform an invaluable service to
236 the faith in the french-speaking nations and islands throughout the world,
237 the bahá’ís dwelling in the Arctic and subarctic regions can powerfully re-
238 inforce the work of the cause in the circumpolar areas, and the friends
239 of hispanic background have fertile fields before them throughout latin
240 America. let all believers consider the extent to which they can use familial
241 and ethnic ties to other regions of the world for the fulfillment of the global mission
conferred on the recipients of the Tablets of the d ivine p lan.

At this critical hour in the fortunes of humanity, our eyes turn with

242 eagerness and hope to the bahá’ís of all parts of North America, who con-

243 stitute a reservoir of human and material resources unmatched elsewhere in the
bahá'í world. As you proceed along your prescribed path, you should be

244 ever mindful of these words addressed to you by the Author of the Tablets of the
divine plan: "i fervently hope that in the near future the whole earth

245 may be stirred and shaken by the results of your achievements. The hope

246 220-7 . Tdp , no. 9.3.220.16

220 17

221 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

222 512which 'Abdu'l-b ahá cherishes for you is that the same success which has at-

223 tended your efforts in America may crown your endeavors in other parts of

224 the world, that through you the fame of the cause of god may be diffused

225 throughout the east and the west, and the advent of the kingdom of the

226 lord of h osts be proclaimed in all the five continents of the globe."220-8

our ardent prayers at the Sacred Threshold will surround and accom-

227 pany you at every step of the momentous undertaking to which you are now
summoned.

228 221

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Europe

Riḍván 153

To the f ollowers of b ahá'u'lláh in e urope

229 dearly loved f riends,

230 forty-three years ago, when the european bahá'ís gathered at the confer-

231 ence in Stockholm called by the beloved guardian for the launching of the

mighty Ten year crusade in your continent, you had but three National

232 Spiritual Assemblies—those of the british isles, of germany and Austria,

233 and of italy and Switzerland—together with slowly developing local com-

234 munities in the other countries of western europe. in the east, cut off by

235 political barriers, were tiny remnants of communities which had been raised

236 up in earlier years and, in neighboring T urkey, was a small, struggling na-tional
community. As the european believers of that time contemplated

237 the awe-inspiring tasks before them, they heard the words of the guardian,
238 illuminating the historical significance of the continent in which they were to build
the institutions of bahá'u'lláh's embryonic world order:

A continent, occupying such a central and strategic position on the

239 entire planet; so rich and eventful in its history, so diversified in its culture; from
whose soil sprang both the hellenic and roman civi-

240 lizations; the mainspring of a civilization to some of whose features bahá'u'lláh
himself paid tribute; on whose southern shores chris-

241 220-8. Tdp , no. 7 .4.220.18

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222 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

223 51tendom first established its home; along whose eastern marches the

mighty forces of the cross and the crescent so frequently clashed; on

whose southwestern extremity a fast-evolving islamic culture yielded

224 its fairest fruit; in whose heart the light of the reformation shone so

225 brightly, shedding its rays as far as the outlying regions of the globe. . . .

226 221-1

This, your continent, whose soil was blessed by the footsteps of

227 bahá'u'lláh himself, which was twice visited by 'Abdu'l-bahá in his epoch-

228 making journeys following his release from imprisonment, whose travelers

229 and scholars early responded to the dawning light of the bábí revelation,

230 two of whose governments extended the hand of succor during the heroic

231 Age of the faith, and whose nations, in recent years, have intervened so

232 effectively in defense of the persecuted bahá'ís in iran, has amply demon-

233 strated the capacity of its people to rally to the banner of the cause of god,

234 once their hearts are touched and their minds awakened to its message.

235 in the course of these forty-three years the european bahá'í communities

236 have shown great vitality. The number of National Spiritual Assemblies has risen to
thirty-four, covering the entire continent and embracing, in the case of russia, vast territories
as far as the pacific ocean. great victories

237 have been won for the faith by european pioneers in Africa, the pacific,

238 the caribbean region and greenland. your institutions have distinguished
239 themselves in external affairs. your communities include outstanding schol-
240 ars of the faith, musicians, artists, scientists and those concerned with the
241 application of bahá'í Teachings to economics and business. you have ex-
242 erted special efforts for the advancement of women and the strengthening of family
life. The european bahá'í youth council provides a focal point and
243 a source of stimulation to the youth in all parts of europe, complemented

by a network of National and local youth committees closely linked to

244 and supported by their National and local Spiritual Assemblies. Now is the
245 time to build on these achievements, clearly focusing all efforts on the cen-tral
purpose of taking the message of bahá'u'lláh to a spiritually famished
246 population.

247 The first task of your National Spiritual Assemblies immediately after
248 riḫván will be to formulate, in consultation with the counselors, the details
249 221-1. ud, p. 319.221.2

221 3

221 4

222 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

223 51of the four year plan, country by country. The participation of the local
224 Spiritual Assemblies and individual believers in evolving their own local
225 plans, and in following the lines of action to be clearly laid down, will be
226 essential for the successful achievement of the high aims of this stage of the
implementation of the d ivine p lan of 'Abdu'l-b ahá.

europe is a continent of great variety, and each of your National As-

227 semblies will be studying with care the processes and achievements required for the
advancement of the cause of god in its area during the coming four

228 years. each must consider the current condition of its community, the ter-
229 ritory within which it is working, and areas of potential collaboration with
230 other bahá'í communities. Special attention will need to be paid to the at-
231 tainment of official recognition in those countries where the institutions of
232 the faith are not yet legally incorporated, and to raising up National Spiri-

233 tual Assemblies in certain of those independent countries and major islands, such as
the faroes, which have not yet attained them. There are, however,

234 certain elements of an even wider vision which must be considered as they apply to
specific countries, groups of countries and the entire continent.

235 There are areas which cry out for pioneers and traveling teachers; the

236 mind turns, for example, to the work among the Sami and the other peoples of the
Arctic and subarctic areas as far north as Spitsbergen. we contem-

237 plate the significance of teaching the faith in the islands of the mediter-

238 ranean, the Atlantic and the North Sea; the continent-wide importance of the romany
peoples, who have begun to show such receptivity to the call

239 of bahá'u'lláh; the opportunity for the european bahá'í communities to

240 demonstrate the salutary nature of the Teachings in relation to minorities of every
kind; the specific tasks described by the beloved guardian as the

241 destiny of certain communities, and their responsibilities in far-flung lands where
their languages are spoken; the implications of the advancement of

242 the faith in italy where is to be found "the heart and stronghold of the

243 leading, the most ancient and powerful church of christendom"; the need

244 to rapidly increase the number of bahá'í centers in the vast areas of the

245 ukraine and european russia; and, beyond this, the special responsibilities

246 and opportunities of the bahá'í community of the russian federation, the

247 larger part of whose area lies in Asia and must continue to benefit from col-

248 laboration with neighboring communities of central, southern and eastern

249 Asia as well as Alaska, canada and the united States. All these are but some

examples of the challenges which you face in the years ahead.221.5

221 6

222 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

223 515The central aim of the four year plan, a significant advance in the pro-

224 cess of entry by troops, is of especial significance for europe. you should

225 have no misgivings—it is a process that can advance in all parts of europe,

226 in the west as well as in the east. All should recognize that entry by troops

227 is an inevitable stage in the development of the cause. The nature of the

228 process is clarified in the compilation on the subject,221-2 whence it becomes

229 apparent that the desired outcome, a sustained entry by troops, cannot be achieved
by a mere series of spasmodic, uncoordinated exertions, no matter how enthusiastic.
confidence; unity of vision; systematic, realistic,

230 but audacious planning; acceptance of the fact that mistakes will be made,
231 and willingness to learn from these mistakes; and, above all, reliance on
232 the guidance and sustaining confirmations of bahá'u'lláh will advance this
233 process.

234 The establishment of training institutes in various locations is empha-
235 sized in the four year plan because current methods, valuable though they
236 are, are not adequate by themselves to meet the challenges of this new stage in the
growth of the cause. The character and structure of the training insti-

237 tutes must be adapted to the conditions of each country and region; clearly their form
in europe will not be identical with that of training institutes in

238 the rural areas of india. Their essential functions, however, will be the same.

239 They will foster a firm acceptance of bahá'í identity in those who take part:

240 the capacity to look upon the world and its conditions from the point of view of the
Teachings rather than from the standpoint of one's nationality or non-b ahá'í background.
They will help to develop in each participant a

241 deep love for bahá'u'lláh, a good understanding of his essential Teachings

242 and an awareness of the importance of developing the spiritual life of each individual
through prayer, meditation and immersion in the Sacred writ-

243 ings. They will also cover such practical matters as how to teach the faith,

244 for there are too many who, for lack of confidence in their ability to do so, are hesitant
to convey the message. The transformation that such deepening

245 in the faith produces will surely inflame the hearts of the individual friends

246 with the longing to share this message with those around them, and this

247 is the seed of all success in teaching. Those who have attended training institutes will
be able to help the other bahá'ís, new and old, to increase

248 221-2. See cc 3, pp. 154-203.221.7

221 8

222 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

223 516their potential for teaching, and so to greatly increase the human resources

224 of the cause, in which every believer is a teacher.

The teaching of the faith by the friends in europe must increase in

225 range; it must be varied, spontaneous and individual on the one hand, and focused,
united and mutually supportive on the other. it must be both in-

226 spiring and practical and must, above all, be informed with serene faith in
227 the power of bahá'u'lláh. you should widen the field of your teaching work
228 to include the country people and the masses laboring in the cities; people
229 of little education as well as intellectuals in university towns. you should
230 consciously approach every stratum of society, adapting your methods,
231 literature and audiovisual materials to each audience. both the heart and
232 the mind need to be fed; both spiritual force and intellectual clarity must
233 be recognized as vital elements of the teaching work. you have excelled in
234 the use of the arts for the proclamation, expansion and consolidation of the faith; this
is a key to opening many doors and should be encouraged and
235 developed. your unity, enthusiasm, confidence and perseverance, strength-
236 ened and guided by the power of prayer, cannot fail to act as a channel for
237 divine confirmations, which will be a magnet to seeking souls.
238 for our part, we shall pray ardently at the Sacred Threshold that you,

who have won such historic victories in your homelands and throughout

239 the world, will enter during the four year plan into a stage of even greater
240 achievement, presaging the as yet unimaginable glories destined to unfold during the
twenty-first century.

241 222

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Africa

Riḍván 153

To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in Africa

242 dearly loved friends,
243 you come to the four year plan with an extraordinary history of achieve-
244 ment, which indicates that you are well equipped spiritually and adminis-tratively,
and in the inherent potential of your people, to respond success-fully to the plan's central
aim to advance the process of entry by troops.

245 in whatever direction south of the Sahara one may look—whether to the 221.9

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 223 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 224 517eastern, western, central or southern region of the continent—portents of
 225 great, imminent expansion are evident. The torch of faith burns brightly
 226 in your hearts, setting our spirits aglow with gladness at the scale of your
 227 attainments and the magnificent possibilities that are now yours.
 228 The bright hope inspired by such observations is justified by thrilling
 229 facts. The spiritual endowments of Africa derive naturally from the creative
 230 forces universally released by the revelation of bahá'u'lláh, but these have
 231 been marvelously enhanced by the continent's direct associations with the
 232 channels of such forces: the ship transporting the blessed beauty on his
 233 exile to the holy land touched briefly its northern shores; the center of
 234 the covenant spent extended periods in egypt before and after his historic
 235 visit to the west. The continent was also twice crossed from south to north
 236 by the beloved guardian. bahá'u'lláh favored the black peoples by making a
 237 specific reference to them when, as the master testified, he compared them
 238 to the "black pupil of the eye" through which "the light of the spirit shineth forth."
 239 222-1

African bahá'í history had its beginnings in egypt, which was opened

240 to the faith during the period of the ministry of bahá'u'lláh; it gathered

momentum during the ministry of 'Abdu'l-b ahá when bahá'í localities

241 were established in South Africa and T unisia. but the early effects of these
 242 spiritual endowments became more obvious with the remarkable success of the
 two-year Africa project (1951–53) when 16 territories were opened,
 243 bringing to 25 the total number of countries and islands in which bahá'ís
 244 resided; this preceded the opening of the 33 virgin territories called for in the beloved
 guardian's Ten year global crusade, a period of astonishing

development in Africa that evoked the admiration and praise of Shoghi

245 effendi as many people from different tribes entered the cause, a num-
 246 ber of administrative institutions were formed, and it became possible to
 247 raise up the mother Temple of Africa in the heart of the continent. during

248 the course of these rapid developments, the African believers themselves, through
sacrificial effort as teachers and pioneers, arose to champion the cause of god, manifesting
the profundity of their response to the message

249 of the New day.

in the countries lying to the north where programs of public teaching

250 cannot now be pursued, the friends have continued for many years to maintain their
posts with circumspection and heroic fortitude. Not only

251 222-1. Abl, p. 68.222.2

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223 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

224 518 have they kept the flame of faith alive in their hearts, they also endeavor to

225 transmit the fire of the love of god to members of their families, including

226 their children and youth, in anticipation of the day when freedom to openly proclaim
their religion and conduct their community affairs is secured.

with immense gratification we now look back over just a few decades

227 during which Africa attained the largest number of National Spiritual As-

228 semblies of any continent; moreover, Africa's local Spiritual Assemblies

229 amount to a substantial percentage of the world's total. The prodigious out-

230 put of energy devoted to expansion and consolidation has included major endeavors
to train the believers and to mount and maintain development

231 projects. As a result the African bahá'í community can boast of notable

232 progress in the establishment of a number of primary and secondary schools

233 and training institutes. A source of much of this energy in recent times

234 has been the African youth, who have increasingly demonstrated exemplary

235 dedication and vigor in their bahá'í activities. in the field of external af-

236 fairs, the African community, whether in small or large states, has shown a boldness,
a creativity, and a tenacity that have resonated in the worldwide

237 proclamation of the faith and the promotion of its vital interests.

238 clearly, then, Africa is poised to register a victory for the cause that

239 will reaffirm its position among the front ranks of our world community.

240 The time is critical, and you must act promptly to realize this prospect. we

241 therefore urge our African brothers and sisters to take immediate account of their
strengths, needs and opportunities, and then resolve to turn the challenge posed by these
conditions into the means of success. you will

242 of necessity give concentrated attention to various plans and programs of activity if
you are to advance to new stages of entry by troops, but simultaneously certain underlying
requisites will claim your special vigilance and exertion. These are the elimination of tribal
prejudice, the transformation

243 of prevailing social practices, and the fostering of education.

244 Tribal conflict is one of the most pressing issues facing Africa. This must
245 be dealt with in the heart of every faithful follower of bahá'u'lláh and reso-
246 lutely overcome through the collective will of every local and national bahá'í
247 community. indeed, how can the lovers of the blessed beauty allow tribal
248 prejudice and rivalry to be practiced in their midst when he has made unity
249 the pivotal principle and goal of his faith? hatred and animosity based
250 on tribe, like those based on race, blight the human spirit and arrest the
251 development of the society that accommodates them. if outside the bahá'í
252 community in recent years influential persons and public officials have been 222.5
222 6

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223 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

224 519able to see the practical benefit of bringing diverse groups together towards

unity, how much more should it be possible for those imbued with the

225 spirit of our Teachings to strive to eliminate within the bahá'í fellowship
226 the unsavory characteristics of tribal division and disunity. it is impera-
227 tive and urgent in the current state of society for the bahá'ís so to practice
228 genuine unity among themselves and in their relations to others that they may
become renowned as a new people in the eyes of all Africans. Such a
229 demonstration will attract divine confirmations and greatly reinforce their power to
succeed in spreading the Teachings.

much of what distinguishes African life is to be found in patterns of

230 behavior displayed in the tribe and particularly in the family. increasingly,
231 urban life threatens to destroy the positive qualities of such patterns. Since change is
inevitable if progress is to be made by any African society, a prima-

232 ry challenge to bahá'ís is to preserve and improve those wholesome aspects
 233 of tribal and family custom that are in accord with the bahá'í Teachings
 234 and to dispense with those that are not. Such a challenge must be embraced
 235 with the understanding that the book of god is the standard by which to
 236 weigh all forms of behavior. while unwavering action is necessary, wisdom
 237 and tact and patience must, of course, be exercised. let it be understood,
 238 too, that Africans are not alone in the struggle to change certain age-old practices.
 people everywhere have customs which must be abandoned so
 239 as to clear the path along which their societies must evolve towards that glorious,
 new civilization which is to be the fruit of bahá'u'lláh's stupendous
 240 revelation. indeed, in no society on earth can there be found practices
 241 which adequately mirror the standards of his cause. his own truth-bearing

words clarify the matter: "The summons and the message which we gave

242 were never intended to reach or to benefit one land or one people only. mankind in
 its entirety must firmly adhere to whatsoever hath been re-
 243 vealed and vouchsafed unto it. Then and only then will it attain unto true liberty. The
 whole earth is illuminated with the resplendent glory of god's

revelation."

244 222-2

The acute inadequacy of plans and programs to educate Africa's people

245 poses a particular challenge to the followers of bahá'u'lláh in that continent,
 246 for he has emphasized the importance of education for all; and individu-
 247 als ought to be taught at least to read and write. The education of which
 248 222-2. Tb, p. 89.222.8

222 9

223 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

224 520bahá'u'lláh spoke includes both spiritual and material aspects. The lack of
 225 such education affects the ability of people to achieve true progress. This
 226 matter should be of the keenest interest to all segments of the community.
 227 parents have a special responsibility to see that their children, both boys and
 228 girls, receive an education; and they must take care that the girls are not left behind,
 since well-educated girls are a guarantee of the excellence of future

229 society; indeed, preference should, if necessary, be given to their education.
230 closely linked to this concern is the principle of the equality of men and women
taught by bahá'u'lláh. it is also highly desirable for adults, both men
231 and women, who are illiterate to participate in literacy programs, so that
232 gradually all bahá'ís will be able to read the word of god for themselves.
233 The bahá'í community is not fully equipped to undertake what responsible
234 authorities have neglected to do for the education of the people; however, the bahá'í
institutions at all levels are urged to give attention to these critical
235 needs, as circumstances permit.

bearing in mind these three foregoing considerations, you can move

236 vigorously and wisely to tackle the manifold tasks implied by the plan's
237 emphasis on advancing the process of entry by troops. An extension of your
238 efforts to effect both expansion and consolidation on a wholly new scale is
imperative. The one suggests a powerful outward thrust of your teach-ing activities to cover
the length and breadth of your countries, reaching
239 the remotest areas with the divine message. The other indicates a drive to
240 consolidate and multiply your gains through an ever-deepening penetra-
241 tion of spiritual knowledge of the faith into the hearts of the believers, a
242 systematic development of human resources, and a marked improvement in the
functioning of your national and, particularly, your local institutions.

in all this exertion, the three components of the process—the indi-

243 vidual, the institutions and the community—must assume their respective
244 responsibilities. we especially expect you all to pursue every means at your
245 disposal that will bring about the realization of an organic unity between the
246 local Spiritual Assembly and the community, and thereby establish a sharp contrast
to the fragmentation of present-day social life. Thus, we long to see
247 the individual African believers arise in greater numbers to claim the faith
248 of bahá'u'lláh as their own and to take on the requisite tasks of teaching
249 and administering a rapidly expanding faith. And we look for accumulating
250 evidence that the Spiritual Assemblies are taking to heart their god-given
251 mandate and are conscientiously fulfilling their obligations to bahá'u'lláh to
252 foster the growth and development of vibrant communities in which adults, 222.10

222 11

223 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

224 521youth and children are more and more integrated and active. To fulfill these
225 expectations is to demonstrate to a skeptical world the power of the faith to
226 hold aloft a new standard for the guidance of the nations, and eventually to attract
the disillusioned masses to the security of g o d ’ s f a i t h .

what specific actions, you may well ask, would indicate that you are

227 fulfilling the basic requirement of the plan in Africa? A reply would include

mention of the following. whatever the state of expansion in a commu-

228 nity, take the next steps to increase enrollments, deepen the believers and strengthen
the teaching force. where entry by troops is in progress, intensify

229 your efforts to stimulate further increase in the number of believers, while

230 at the same time conducting a program of training that will deepen the new

231 believers and raise up new teachers on a continuing basis. maximize action

232 to bring families into the faith by encouraging individuals in their duty to

233 endeavor to lead as many of their family members as possible to the light of divine
guidance. regularize efforts to teach among the sub-Saharan mus-

234 lims. proliferate the publication of bahá’í literature and audiocassette tapes,

235 especially in vernacular languages. Swell the number of local Spiritual As-

236 semblies elected by their communities without help from outside. Support more
abundantly the funds of the faith. orient believers from among the

237 traditional rulers to the Teachings, so that they will find appropriate ways to serve
the f a i t h .

238 moreover, extend provisions for children regularly to attend bahá’í classes

239 for their spiritual training. give consistent attention to involving the youth

240 in the expansion and consolidation work and to opening channels of activ-

241 ity suited to their talents and necessary for their development into mature

242 bahá’ís. increase the number and effectiveness of observances of Nineteen

day feasts. expand the use of music and drama in the proclamation and

243 teaching work, an effort in which Africa has already distinguished itself.

244 multiply plans and programs to raise the status of women and to encourage

245 the active support of men in such endeavors. extend the range of your exer-

246 tions in the fields of external affairs and social and economic development.

247 you will readily appreciate, then, the emphasis placed on multiplying the
248 number of training institutes; for without them it will be impossible to meet
249 the needs of hugely expanding communities. in some places, the friends
250 may find it possible to offer sites and facilities for these essential operations,
251 which must be located in as many areas as necessary to provide regular and
252 well-organized training to increasing numbers of believers. The programs of the
institutes must be designed to instill in the participants a good under-222.12

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223 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

224 522standing of the fundamental verities of the faith and to help them acquire
225 skills and abilities that will enable them to serve the f aith effectively.

226 immediately after riḫvān your National Spiritual Assemblies will initiate
227 efforts to formulate, in consultation with the counselors, the details of the
228 four year plan, country by country. To ensure that the plan is broadly based
229 and responsive to the needs of all areas of a country, the participation of
230 the local Spiritual Assemblies and individuals, in evolving their own local
231 plans and in following the lines of action to be clearly laid down, will be
232 essential.

233 dear friends, we are acutely conscious of the crushing difficulties that
234 afflict life in Africa: the conditions that have caused a flood of refugees on the
continent, the horrors created by ethnic conflict, the political unrest, the economic distress,
the high incidence of hunger and disease, the horrendous
235 natural disasters. but, paradoxical as it may seem, there exist in all of these
236 the very possibilities of your success. your ability to endure and forge ahead
237 is reinforced in the assurance given by the divine physician, who antici-
238 pated all these conditions and prescribed a sure remedy. his prescriptions
239 have been placed in your hands.

Therefore, we remind you of the noble ambitions the beloved guardian

240 held for you as a people in a continent that has “a great contribution to make
to the advancement of world civilization.” may such memories resound

241 afresh in your hearts, quickening your will to fulfill the major aim of the plan before
you, and setting a pace for your actions like the urgent rhythm

242 of drums pulsating throughout your immensely potent, far-stretching land.

our ardent prayer at the holy Threshold on your behalf is that the

243 divine storehouses of heaven may pour out their bounties upon you all, healing your
ills, magnifying your powers, and enabling you to achieve vic-tory upon victory.

222 16

222 17

222 18

223 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

224 52223

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Western and Central Asia

Riḍván 153

To the f ollowers of b ahá’u’lláh in w estern and central Asia

225 dearly loved f riends,

226 As a turbulent yet luminous century draws to a close, the bahá’í com -

227 munity is embarking on another campaign in the progressive unfoldment of

228 the divine plan. The global enterprises thus far executed by the consecrated

229 adherents of his cause have systematically spread the light of bahá’u’lláh’s

230 revelation to every corner of the earth and have firmly established the institu -

231 tions of his Administrative order. The four year plan, whose primary aim

232 is to effect a significant advance in the process of entry by troops, is being

233 launched at a time when the cause of god has emerged from obscurity, when

234 its contributions to society are being increasingly acknowledged, and when

235 humanity’s prolonged and continuous suffering has created an atmosphere of

236 search for spiritual values and has raised the level of receptivity to the cause.

237 we call upon our much-loved coworkers in the western and central parts

238 of the Asiatic continent, the home of the oldest and most venerable bahá’í

239 communities, to rally round their divinely ordained institutions and to arise during
these years to demonstrate once again the devotion, valor and deter-

240 mination which have already conferred matchless distinction upon them. you have
the honor of serving the faith in a region above whose horizon the

dawn of the great day of the lord appeared, in whose bosom the infant

241 cause of god was nurtured, on whose soil so much sacred blood was shed,
242 on whose western shores the qiblih of the people of bahá is established,
243 within whose embrace the first mashriqu'l-A dhkár was raised, and from
244 which hosts of devoted and committed bahá'ís have, in the past decades, set
245 out to bear the banner of the faith to every part of the globe.
246 our thoughts turn first to the community of bahá'u'lláh's lovers in the
247 land where his faith was born. Although they are still denied the freedom
248 to resume direct participation in the series of campaigns by which the cause
249 is steadily advancing throughout the world, their achievements constitute irrefutable
proof of the creative power of the daily sacrifices they are mak-ing for the vindication of the
faith. what is becoming apparent, as this

250 new global plan opens, is that the build-up of spiritual strength within the 223.1

223 2

223 3

224 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

225 52iranian bahá'í community—purified by suffering and steeled by adver-

226 sity—represents a reservoir of energy that will, in god's good time, bring

227 incalculable benefits to the cause. "Say: The springs that sustain the life of

228 these birds are not of this world. Their source is far above the reach and ken

of human apprehension."223-1

229 in the lands to the south and west of iran, bahá'ís live under restrictions

230 which prevent them from teaching the cause to their fellow-countrymen.

231 yet, by the outstanding contributions they have made to the progress of the

232 faith in other parts of the world, they have proved that their enthusiasm to

233 spread the divine message cannot be dampened. it has been particularly

234 heartening to witness the eagerness and rapidity with which, as soon as the

235 barriers to teaching in the republics of central Asia and the caucasus were

236 removed, they rushed to the aid of the small bands of believers who had

237 persevered there for so many decades and helped them to build the vibrant
 communities now flourishing in these regions today. No doubt they will
 238 continue to lend valuable assistance to the communities in central Asia and
 239 the caucasus during the f our y ear p lan.
 240 in these republics, through the combined efforts of native and visiting
 241 teachers, extraordinary advances can be expected. A pattern for the rapid
 242 growth of the cause has already been established in the region: locality after
 243 locality has been opened to the faith and, because of the high receptivity of
 244 the people, the number of believers in each place has quickly risen, resulting
 245 in the election of a Spiritual Assembly to guide the affairs of the nascent
 246 community. integral to this pattern, almost from the very outset, has been
 247 the holding of regular institute courses, which have assisted the friends in becoming
 strong promoters of the cause. if the expansion and consolida-
 248 tion activities are vigorously pursued according to this same pattern in the coming
 years, the growth of the faith will accelerate, greatly increasing the
 249 number of believers and centers.
 250 To effect such accelerated growth, the friends in these countries must be-
 251 come so deepened in their understanding of the faith as to take up, on their
 252 own initiative, the torch of guidance that will enlighten the multitudes. They should
 not be content with small communities, nor allow the tasks of
 253 administering their own community affairs to divert them from the essential
 254 purpose of bringing new members into their ranks. each community, from
 255 223-1. gwb, no. 163.2.223.4
 223 5
 223 6
 224 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 225 525the earliest phases of its development, should be fired by a vision of the
 226 glory of the cause and imbued with the zeal to achieve rapid and sustained
 227 expansion both in the locality itself and in the nearby towns and villages.

in pakistan, where a well-grounded community traces its roots back

228 some hundred years, the friends must make a mighty effort to increase their numbers
 significantly among people of every walk of life. The will and de-

229 termination needed to sustain large-scale expansion and consolidation can
 230 be created through a consistent and widespread institute program aimed at exposing
 growing contingents of believers to the creative word, thus
 231 enhancing their spiritual capacities to diffuse the light of the faith and to
 232 further the development of its institutions. Such a rapid process of growth requires
 that more and more women be enabled to move to the forefront of bahá'í activity, in both the
 teaching and administrative fields. while ris-
 233 ing to the challenge of entry by troops in their homeland, the friends in pakistan need
 also to pay special attention to their long-suffering Afghan
 234 neighbors, who cry out for the healing message of bahá'u'lláh, the one true
 235 balm for their afflictions.

in all your countries, you must continue to give the highest priority

236 to the education of children. having seen the effects of the Teachings of
 237 bahá'u'lláh on generation after generation, you well understand the value
 238 of bahá'í education and of a proper spiritual upbringing. in those areas
 239 where activities are restricted, you are nevertheless able to teach the chil-dren of your
 own communities and help them to grow to become pillars of strength. in other areas, you
 have the possibility, nay the obligation, to open
 240 your classes to children of non-b ahá'í families and to become known as the
 241 educators of the coming generations of your peoples.
 242 dear friends, the time is short, and weighty responsibilities have been
 243 placed on the shoulders of each and every bahá'í. in his most holy book,
 244 the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the b lessed b eauty states:

verily, we behold you from our realm of glory, and will aid who-

soever will arise for the triumph of our cause with the hosts of the

245 concourse on high and a company of o ur favored angels.

246 223-2

247 223-2. kA, ¶53.223.7

223 8

223 9

223 9a

224 m eS Sa g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

225 526be confident that your dedicated services will, like a magnet, attract
 226 the promised confirmations and that your hearts will be gladdened as you
 227 witness the successive triumphs of the cause you hold so dear. we shall
 228 remember all of you in our prayers in the holy Shrines and shall beseech
 229 bahá'u'lláh to guide and assist you, as you face the many challenges of these
 230 spiritually potent closing years of the century.
 231 224

Supplementary Message—Riḍván Message 1996—

Pacific Region

Riḍván 153

232 To the followers of bahá'u'lláh in Australia, the cook islands, the eastern
 233 caroline islands, the fiji islands, french polynesia, the hawaiian islands,
 234 indonesia, japan, kiribati, korea, the mariana islands, the marshall islands,
 235 New caledonia and the loyalty islands, New zealand, papua New guinea,
 236 the philippines, Samoa, the Solomon islands, Tonga, T uvalu, vanuatu, and

the w estern caroline i slands

237 dearly loved f riends,
 238 you are privileged to live in a region of the world unique in the oppor-
 239 tunities it offers to advance the interests of the faith during the course of
 240 the four year plan. you constitute bahá'í communities within, or on the
 241 fringe of, the vast pacific ocean, with which is associated this promise of
 242 bahá'u'lláh: "Should they attempt to conceal his light on the continent, he
 243 will assuredly rear his head in the midmost part of the ocean and, raising
 244 his voice proclaim: 'i am the life-giver of the world.'"224-1 At a time when
 245 the dear bahá'í friends in the cradle of the faith yearn for the yoke of
 246 oppression to be lifted from their shoulders, you can compensate for their
 247 present and temporary inability to propagate the faith if you undertake a
 248 sustained endeavor to convey the divine message to the peoples of your
 249 countries and multiply b ahá'í institutions throughout these lands.
 250 within your region is to be found a vast diversity of races, cultures,

251 languages and religious traditions, illustrative of the major influences which
 252 224-1. wob, p. 78.223.10
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 224 2
 225 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 226 527have shaped the affairs of humanity throughout history. one of this re-
 227 gion’s distinguishing features is described by the guardian as “a spiritual
 228 axis, extending from the Antipodes to the northern islands of the pacific
ocean—an axis whose northern and southern poles will act as powerful
 229 magnets, endowed with exceptional spiritual potency, and towards which
 230 other younger and less experienced communities will tend for some time
 231 to gravitate.”224-2 This emphasizes the vital role to be played by the bahá’í
 232 communities of Northeastern Asia and of the Antipodes in the spiritual illumination
 of the surrounding areas.
 233 every country of the region must witness, in the course of the four year
 234 plan, a significant advance in the process of entry by troops. it is essential
 235 that the plans formulated on national and local levels reflect this vital aim. The
 advancement of this process will require that greater attention be given
 236 not only to fostering individual initiative in the teaching work, but also to developing
 human resources through the establishment and efficient op-eration of training institutes
 and other centers of learning, and to vastly
 237 increasing the strength and quality of the functioning of the local Spiritual
 238 Assemblies.
 239 we direct a special appeal to the indigenous believers in all parts of the
 240 pacific region, men and women alike, to intensify their efforts to acquire a
 241 deeper understanding of the revelation of bahá’u’lláh, and to strive for a
 242 position in the forefront of the promoters of the faith through their teach-
 243 ing endeavors on the home front and their international cooperation in programs of
 the ocean of light. As the tensions and divisions of a declining
 244 social order increase, the believers throughout the pacific islands should pro-
 245 vide compelling testimony to the potency of the bahá’í Teachings through
 246 their manifest unity transcending tribal, national or ethnic barriers. The desperate
 search for solutions to the social and economic problems afflict-

247 ing these countries is tempting people, in increasing numbers, to indulge in partisan
political activities; the indigenous bahá'ís should refuse to be

248 drawn into such divisive pursuits and should strive to acquire a more pro-found
insight into the nature of the world order of bahá'u'lláh, which

249 offers a pattern for a future society distinguished by justice and unity, far removed
from the contention of competing political interests.

in many of the nations of your area, women have traditionally been

250 restricted to a secondary role in the life of society. we call upon the

251 224-2. jTA, p. 89.224.3

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225 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

226 528bahá'í women of these countries, assured of the support and encourage-

227 ment of all elements of the bahá'í community, to demonstrate the trans-

228 forming power of this revelation by their courage and initiative in the

229 teaching work and their full participation in the administrative activities

230 of the faith.

231 in much of the region, insufficient attention has been given to the educa-

232 tion of children. far more extensive programs should be initiated in those

233 countries where the need exists, to ensure that bahá'í children are nurtured,

234 encouraged to acquire trained minds, illumined with a sound knowledge of the
divine Teachings, well-equipped to participate in the work of the cause

235 at all levels and to contribute to the arts, crafts and sciences necessary for the
advancement of civilization. Such programs, when open to all children, bahá'í or not, offer a
potent means of extending the beneficial influences of

236 bahá'u'lláh's message to the wider society.

237 in Northeastern Asia, the progress of the faith has been most encourag-

238 ing, and a good foundation has been laid for the bahá'ís of japan and ko-

239 rea to magnify the size of their communities substantially during the four

240 year plan, while making a notable contribution to the work of the faith in

241 neighboring countries. Special attention should be given to the develop-ment of the
faith in the ryukyu islands and also to the exploration of any

242 opportunities which might arise to carry the healing message of bahá'u'lláh

243 to all parts of the Korean peninsula.

The dedication and vitality of the bahá'í community in the philippine

244 islands is a constant source of joy to us. we look to the filipino believers to
245 make a significant advance in the process of entry by troops during the four
246 year plan, while giving renewed attention to the strengthening of their lo-
247 cal Spiritual Assemblies and the development of community life. This will necessitate
the intensive use of training institutes throughout the country,
248 and the involvement of a larger number of believers in these training pro-

grams. The members of this devoted bahá'í community provide a welcome

249 source of manpower for the reinforcement of bahá'í endeavors elsewhere,
250 particularly in the Asian and Pacific regions.
251 we are well aware of the restrictions which have long afflicted the mem-
252 bers of the Indonesian bahá'í community. Their staunchness of faith, and
253 their initiative in taking full advantage of whatever opportunities are open
254 to them, attract our admiration and gratitude. we urge them to continue
255 their endeavors throughout the whole of Indonesia, with full confidence

that their hopes will be fulfilled in the future.224.6

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225 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

226 529A special responsibility must rest upon the believers in Papua New Guinea,
227 constituting the largest body of bahá'ís in Australasia, to strive unceasingly
228 to build a vibrant community which embraces all strata of society and which
229 is renowned as a dynamic and enlightened segment of their nation. we look
230 forward, in the course of the four year plan, to a greater participation of the
231 bahá'í men and women of this country in the development of the faith in
232 other parts of Melanesia and elsewhere throughout the Pacific islands.

in Australia, New Zealand and Hawaii, there are well-established and

233 soundly functioning bahá'í communities, each characterized by an admi-
234 rable record of accomplishments on the home front and by a notable con-

235 tribution to the work of the faith in other parts of the pacific and beyond.
 236 we call upon the believers in these countries to strive for a fuller realization
 237 of their duty to advance the interests of the faith on the home fronts and
 238 throughout the length and breadth of the pacific region. in their own coun-
 239 tries, they should aspire to far greater attainments, marked by a substantial
 240 increase in the number of adherents and an enhanced public awareness of the
 distinctive character of the bahá'í faith and its followers. They can
 241 render invaluable assistance to other bahá'í communities, not only in the
 242 pacific region but in Southeast Asia and beyond, because of the experi-
 243 ence they have acquired in the teaching and administrative fields and the resources to
 which they have access. The believers from the pacific islands
 244 who have taken up residence in these three countries should be mindful of the
 responsibilities which rest upon them to devise means by which they can contribute to the
 strengthening of the bahá'í communities in the island
 245 nations from which they have come.
 246 many of the valiant bahá'í communities of the pacific islands are dis-
 247 tinguished by the fact that they constitute significant percentages of the populations
 of their countries. The believers in these island nations need to
 248 direct their attention, more than ever, to the propagation of the faith. They
should also concentrate on the development of a distinctive community
 249 life, based on an uncompromising adherence to the precepts of the faith,
and guided by well-functioning local Spiritual Assemblies, which will
 250 demonstrate to the entire populations of their countries the unifying and
 transforming power of the faith, and will attract to the cause a multitude
 251 of new believers. Through this effort, they can make a vital contribution to
 252 enhancing the worldwide prestige of the faith, and can lay the foundation
 253 for even more outstanding victories in the future. we urge them to give
 254 attention to sharply increasing their level of international cooperation in 224.10
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 224 12
 225 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 226 50pursuit of the goals of the four year plan, including support of the estab-
 227 lishment of a strong bahá'í community in french polynesia as a basis for the

228 future election of a National Spiritual Assembly there.

229 Almost four decades have passed since Shoghi effendi described the pa-

230 cific region in which you live as "that vast area of the globe, an area endowed

231 with unimaginable potentialities, and which, owing to its strategic posi-

232 tion, is bound to feel the impact of world-shaking forces, and to shape to a

233 marked degree through the experience gained by its peoples in the school of

adversity, the destinies of mankind."

234 224-3 Since that time your nations have

235 come ever more fully under the influence of the forces which are causing tur-

236 moil and disorder to human society, while the followers of bahá'u'lláh have

237 labored, undeterred and with admirable dedication, to advance the cause

238 of their lord and to establish his institutions. The pacific area, where, as

239 the guardian stated, "b ahá'í exploits bid fair to outshine the feats achieved

240 in any other ocean, and indeed in every continent of the globe. . . , "224-4

241 now stands at the threshold of victories far greater than any yet won. we call

242 upon you to go forward now as never before, assured of our ardent prayers

243 in the h oly Shrines on your behalf, confident of your ultimate triumph.

244 225

Our Sacred Duty to Teach the Faith

and the Role of the Institutions

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]